

Media Infopack 2

Contents

Introduction to Media	2
The Power of the Media.....	3
The Relevance of the Media today	9
The Impacts of the Media	10
Advertisements	12
Censorship.....	17
Case Studies	24
Essay Outlines involving Media	26
Can media be relied to tell the truth?	26
New media vs. Traditional	27
Book vs. Internet	29
Narcissism	31
Private life of public figures	32
Celebrity as a role model	34
Blame media for our problems	36
Media ethics	37
New Media and democracy	38
Singapore Media – misconceptions	40
To what extent has media empowered people?	41
To what extent are perceptions manipulated by the media?	43
Should the mass media always tell the truth?	44
To what extent is government control affected by media and technology?	46
Advertising reflects the value of society but does not influence them. What are your views?	48
‘A picture is always more powerful than mere words.’ What is your view?.....	50

Introduction to Media

Brief history of media

Axial age – Caveman drawings for communication

13th to 16th century – Rise of the Book (Renaissance) + invention of paper and Guttenberg's printing press

17th to 19th century – Rise of Newspaper (Industrial revolution) + invention of telegraph, camera, telephone

20th century and beyond – Rise of Modern Media (Digital revolution and Age of Information) – Radio, television, satellites, videos, Internet, social media platforms

Mass media: A section of the media designed to reach a very large audience. It commonly refers to radio networks, news broadcasts, mass-circulation newspapers and magazines. The mass media is a tool for the transfer of information, concepts, and ideas to both general and specific audiences.

Key questions:

- Does the media dilute or develop our culture?
- Does the media preserve or disrupt the socio-political status quo?
- Is the media a tool for all or one for some?

The Power of the Media

1. Mass media is omnipresent and omnipotent

- Average modern person spends 1/3 of his life immersed or exposed to some form of mass media — undeniable influence
 - Global TV penetration rate: 89%
 - Global Internet penetration rate: 40%
- However, digital and electronic media like the internet requires well established and well maintained infrastructure, something that only industrialized and wealthy nations are able to provide
 - Rwanda Internet penetration rate: 8.7%
- That said, mass media has the power to influence elections and topple regimes
 - The Twitter Revolution during the Arab Spring
 - Google's search algorithm can easily shift the voting preferences of undecided voters by 20 percent or more—up to 80 percent in some demographic groups—with virtually no one knowing they are being manipulated (Politico)

2. Mass media dilutes and enhances cultures simultaneously around the world

- America's cultural hegemony has diluted cultures around the world
 - Over the years, we have bought into America's default culture of consumerism and integrated its lifestyle into ours. For better or worse, the world is getting increasingly Americanized. We can all relate to the Golden Arches (McDonalds), the iconic red can (Coca Cola), and the mouse of happy (Mickey).
- It's not just America
 - The spread of Korean Pop Culture, English Culture, Bollywood Culture has influenced and altered the status quo of many countries
 - It has turned the world into one big melting pot. While our cultures may no longer be as distinct as before, we grow increasingly more tolerant of each other's societies and cultures.
- Is it dilution or evolution?
 - The world is finding common cultural ground through the pervasiveness of mass media. We can all relate to the spirit of the Olympics, the glory of the World Cup, but we can still understand the appeal of our local traditions.
 - It's unlikely we are subtracting from the status quo. While we may not be keeping all of our traditions, is advocacy for women's rights and LGBT rights a loss? Maybe teenagers today may prefer McDonalds to old-time Singaporean Laksa, but does that actually make our culture less prevalent or more cherished?

3. Mass media is educational

- The media has been a powerful catalyst for building a culture of intellectual pluralism. It helps to mainstream alternative concepts and ideas, allowing for an increased volume of perspectives in the society. This allows for increased acceptance of non-traditional concepts.
- The media has allowed for increased international flow of information. This has allowed for greater awareness amongst global citizens of transnational events and perspectives.
 - The democratic ideology spread through then-Communist states through a network of underground broadsheets, the radio and the Internet.

- Liberal causes such as the fight for women's rights, human rights, animal rights, LGBT rights, environmentalism gained mass support because of the use of mass media by involved institutions and organizations to help its causes. For example, PETA published its anti-fur campaign aggressively on numerous magazines and through the television.
- Alternative lifestyles have also become increasingly tolerated through mass media. For example, through shows such as The Bachelor, Friends and Modern Family, there has been increasing liberalism wafting through society.

4. However, mass media requires a thinking and informed audience

- We need to understand that mass media re-presents reality to us. It may be an idealized reality or one with an agenda. Sometimes it may be malignant, other times it may be benevolent.
- Every piece of information filtered through someone else's lenses will be recreated in his/her fashion. For example, FOX News is known for being pro-conservatism. In contrast, Bloomberg is known for being Liberal.
- Therefore, we cannot blindly trust the information that we receive. The accuracy of the information we receive must be questioned and accessed.
 - **Stereotyping and caricaturization:** Consider the depictions of different age groups, ethnicities, social classes and genders. Stereotypes distort our understanding of people different from ourselves. We simply absorb what the media presents and we presume that we know the said community or type of individual. Prejudice leads to subconscious discrimination. This is not just poisonous but also pernicious to the social fabric.
 - **Distorted ideas of beauty and aesthetics:** Faced with flawless Photoshopped skin and artificially skinny models, the impressionable might end up having unrealistic ideals of their body and of beauty. This is unhealthy for society and the consumer.
 - **Distorted depiction of historical events or current affairs:** Consider the Great Firewall of China. Searching for anything politically sensitive is a no-no. Google is banned for not cooperating with censorship laws. The government censors politically sensitive topics such as Tiananmen Square online, with a dedicated censorship team filtering through online content.

5. However, mass media can be leveraged by some for personal gain

- Agendas of individuals with significant political or economic clout could utilize advertising dollars to recommend select narratives to the general populace. Incumbents could use the mass media to influence policy making.
 - AirBnB: Spent more than 8 million on mass media in San Francisco to defeat Proposition F, an initiative to restrict short-term rentals.
- Mass media production and distribution is wildly expensive such that only select individuals or institutions have the financial capacity to engage it. At the end of the day, mass media is largely owned by private profit-driven corporations.
- Media giants today behave as large conglomerates that have acted as powerful political lobby groups before on national, regional and global levels.
 - Fox News is known for being republican slanted, CNBC with a democratic slant. Inherent biases have influenced elections and policy makers.
 - Media pressured US politicians to open up trade with China to free up trade and press regulations in 2000.

- Singapore Press Holdings is known for being a ‘mouthpiece’ of the Singapore government, frequently self-censoring and self-policing its content.
- The government will be able to ban and structure media narratives to its advantage: Singapore’s banning of Wired Magazine due to the publication of the article ‘Disneyland with the Death Penalty’.

6. That being said, so long as communication technology continues to advance, alternative voices will emerge to counter them

- While media conglomerates are powerful and rich, none controls the entire global media bandwidth.
- Alternative media sources will always ensure that 2 sides of the story are presented. For every FOX, there will be a CNBC.
- Availability of affordable, off the shelf hardware has enabled the rise of citizen journalism. Able to use our smartphones to capture and upload content on the go.
 - Due to lower barriers to entry, extent of speed and reach as well as a bi-directional conversation between the author and the readers.
 - Barriers to entry: Smartphones are hundreds of times cheaper than traditional broadcasting equipment.
 - Extent of speed and reach: Internet is instantaneous, can distribute information within seconds. Consider real time Facebook Feed and Twitter Hashtags
 - Interactive and bi-directional: Comments and responses allow for 2 sides of the story to be expressed in any article
- Citizen journalism is instantaneous, personal and more provocative because of its deeply personal perspective.
- Consider the Arab Spring and Wikileaks.
- Blogs by Iraqi citizens and American soldiers shaded a different POV on the war in Iraq.

7. Further, the presence of mass media has been instrumental in speeding up change in countries where knowledge used to be suppressed.

- The Protestant cause spread all over Europe because of the printing press. Modern scientific ideas transcended geographical boundaries, inspiring the Renaissance and the scientific revolution.
- The 1989 Tiananmen Square student revolution was initiated by students exposed to democratic ideals through the internet and smuggled literature. They even constructed a Goddess of Democracy that closely resembled the American Statue of Liberty.
- In 2010, One man set himself on fire, sparking protests in Tunisia that toppled Zine El-Abidine Ben Ali and led to the Arab Spring. The Arab Spring was greatly assisted by social media: Facebook, Twitter and other major social media played a key role in the movement of Egyptian and Tunisian activists in particular. Nine out of ten Egyptians and Tunisians responded to a poll that they used Facebook to organize protests and spread awareness.
- In 1997, a small, poor group of Zapatista rebels in Mexico used the internet and broadcasting networks to garner international support and pressured the government to negotiate with them.

8. The media has the ability to play the 4th Estate and behave as the watchdog.

- Act as a check on the other power players in society. If it sees any systemic abuses by the clergy, the nobility or the middle class (the 3 estates), it alerts the rest of society at large. While individuals with vested interests may attempt to clamp down on the media, the diversity and range of media channels we have today means that there is no way to completely shutter the flow of information.
- A responsible and uncensored mass media can encourage a culture of change and challenge citizens to critically question society's sacred cows, monitoring corruption and exploitation.
- Jane Akre and Steve Wilson of FOX News uncovered a conspiracy by Monsanto to cover up the harmfulness of rBGH, a hormone artificially created to enhance the growth of cows. rBGH increases cancer risks and is banned in Canada and Europe but not America. Pressured by parent conglomerate News Corp and the potential loss of advertising dollars from Monsanto, FOX axed the story and the 2 investigative reporters. However, the story still found circulation through alternative media sources.

Media: Good or Bad?

- Nothing is inherently good or bad, and the same goes for mass media.
- The media is a product of us. The ability for the media to serve or detract from our interests is dependent on its interaction with us.
- This means that often times the good that mass media can bring to society is diluted
- We need to ensure that the mass media is kept accountable, fair and just:
 - By the people
 - We need to be media literate to distinguish between propaganda and genuine news stories, to differentiate between stories with hidden agendas and those that are inherently positive to society.
 - By independent media watch groups
 - Consider groups with the UN with its Press Freedom Index, FAIR (Fairness and Accuracy in Reporting) et cetera. These organizations can monitor the ability for news organizations to serve its purpose as the 4th pillar of society.
 - By a free press
 - If the press is allowed to flourish, it can ensure that its own peers uphold public interests.
 - By a representative government
 - We need to have incumbents that believe in freedom of speech and the importance of discourse. Such a government would prevent media monopolies from forming, ensuring that there is sufficient discourse and a balanced number of perspectives in society.

The Role of the Media

The economy, government and society would have great difficulty functioning without the continuing flow of news and information.

The communication process (including serious journalism) in society performs the following broad functions:

1. **Surveillance of the environment, disclosing threats and opportunities affecting the value positions of the community and of its component parts.**
 - Alert nations to dangers as environmental disasters, changing facets of terrorism, human rights clashes, economic trends and crises and incipient political crises.
 - Enables leaders of nation states, suprapowers and business and nongovernmental organizations to respond to such challenges.
 - TV can be manipulated into becoming the final link between terrorist groups and their audiences because the more outrageous and heinous the act, the greater attention the media will give it.
E.g. Terrorists post videos of decapitation of prisoners online.
E.g. Video messages by Osama bin Laden sent to TV broadcasters.
2. **Transmission of social inheritance to the next generation.**
 - American-generated news in print and broadcasting and American culture and lifestyles have penetrated the minds and cultures of Europeans and non-Western people with tremendous impact.
3. **Diplomacy**
 - Foreign relations and the ways that nations react to each other are affected by public (and world) opinion, now often quickly formed by global communication.
 - The capabilities of modern media to be immediate, sensational and pervasive are unsettling the conduct of foreign affairs.
 - Today's correspondents employ laptop computers and wireless telephones that transmit directly to satellites to broadcast vivid pictures and commentary from scenes of tragedy and disorder without the transmission delays, political obstructions or military censorship of old.
4. **Promoting good governance and controlling corruption**
 - **Raise public awareness about corruption** and its causes and consequences by investigating and reporting incidences of corruption.
 - **Consequences:**
 - Arouse the ire of the public → Electoral defeat
 - Prompt public bodies to launch formal investigations into allegations of corruption.
 - The media has exposed corrupt officials, prompted investigations by official bodies, reinforced the work and legitimacy of both parliaments and their anti-corruption bodies and pressured for change to laws and regulations that create a climate favorable to corruption.
 - E.g. President Perez in Venezuela 2 investigative stories in the Caracas daily *El Universal* have been credited with precipitating Perez's downfall. One reported that the president had misappropriated \$17 million in missing discretionary funds and made millions by changing Venezuelan currency into dollars just

ahead of a devaluation. After Venezuelan lawmakers began impeachment proceedings, Perez was forced to step down.

- **By-product of a hard-hitting, independent news media** – checks on corruption which arise from the broader social climate of enhanced political pluralism, enlivened public debate and a heightened sense of accountability among politicians, public bodies and institutions
 - If there is no searchlight on corruption and inequitable practices, you cannot build the public consensus needed to bring about change. — *James D. Wolfensohn, President of the World Bank in a speech to the World Press Freedom Committee*

5. Media representations construct reality

- When consumers have had no direct or immediate experience of the individual, institution, issue, person or place represented, the media tends to mediate. People tend to think of the world as how they see it on TV, for instance.

6. Criticisms

- Centralisation of media power and heavy commercialism are related to the decline of public broadcasting and public service standards for broadcasting. □□ As most media outlets are owned by for-profit corporations and are funded by corporate advertising, **they do not always provide a full range of debate.**
- Under great pressure to boost ratings, **they sensationalise the news:** focusing attention on lurid, highly emotional stories, such as murder cases.
- Indian newspapers such as Times of India ran headline stories for weeks over the murder case of Indian teenager Aarushi Talwar.
- **Evaluation:** Many media outlets still remain dedicated to serious journalism. E.g. CNA in S'pore.

The Relevance of the Media today

Newspapers

Decreasing importance of newspapers and prestige of journalists:

- Many newspapers have been downsizing to increase profitability. Many editors, in pursuit of greater circulation, are stressing more entertainment-oriented, celebrity-soaked infotainment, as well as soft features that relate to the personal concerns of readers.

Survey by the Committee of Concerned Journalists found that news professionals see 2 trends that worry them:

- The news media have blurred the lines between news and entertainment
- The cult of argument is overwhelming the cult of reporting. They sense a degradation of the culture of news – from one that was steeped in verification and a steadfast respect for the facts, toward one that favours argument, opinion-mongering, haste and infotainment.

Evaluation:

Editorials and the Review pages (of The Straits Times) do seem to be argument-based, but these give the reader multiple perspectives of an issue. They add on to views on the ground from readers who write letters to the paper (the Forum page).

The crisis of confidence in the newspaper may be caused by a number of factors:

- The declining number of independently owned papers
- The slow but steady drop for some papers in readership and advertising revenue
- Less interest by the public in serious news
- Competition from the ‘new media’ – cable TV and the Internet.

The future of Chinese newspapers in S’pore:

The declining readership of Lianhe Zaobao implies that the relevance of the Chinese newspaper may be decreasing in Singapore. Circulation has been boosted mainly because of the large number of Chinese immigrants. In reality, the percentage of local readers is diminishing.

This may have adverse consequences in terms of the development of the cultural elite. Chinese nationals are increasingly the main contributors to the Commentary and Forum pages of Zaobao. As they are stronger in Chinese than Singaporeans, locals may feel little confidence to contribute their own views. In the future, Zaobao may no longer reflect the voices of Chinese Singaporeans. As the older generation passes on, it is highly likely that Zaobao can no longer continue to retain its influence among local Chinese on important national issues.

The Impacts of the Media

Positive Impacts

1. **Mass media has ushered in an era of increased efficiency and interconnectedness.**
 - a. It made information easily obtainable and accessible.
 - b. Mass media has been made a mobile source of information through billboards and signs, placards inside and outside of commercial transportation modes, flying billboards (e.g., signs in tow of airplanes), blimps, and skywriting.
 - c. Commercial advertisers such as Goodyear, Fuji, Budweiser, Pizza Hut, and Blockbuster all make extensive use of their logo-bearing blimps around sports stadiums.
 - d. An increasing proportion of Internet users participate in social networking sites from contributing to Wikipedia to downloading YouTube videos.
2. **Mass media performs three key functions: educating, shaping public relations, and advocating for a particular policy or point of view.**
 - a. As education tools, media not only impart knowledge, but can be part of larger efforts (e.g., social marketing) to promote actions having social utility.
 - b. As public relations tools, media assist organizations in achieving credibility and respect among public health opinion leaders, stakeholders, and other gatekeepers.
 - c. As advocacy tools, mass media assist leaders in setting a policy agenda, shaping debates about controversial issues, and gaining support for particular viewpoints.
 - i. When Rudolph Giuliani, the mayor of New York City, publicly disclosed he had prostate cancer prior to the 2000 New York senatorial election, many news media reported the risks of prostate cancer, prompting greater public awareness about the incidence of the disease and the need for screening.
 - ii. On 18th July 2008, the latest “Stop Violence in the Home” campaign was launched in Singapore. Those affected were told to take the first step and speak up about their abuse – by confiding in a friend.
 - iii. Mass media have been major sources of information about HIV/AIDS and other sexually transmitted infections.
 - iv. Providing media posters in hospitals and clinics helps remind asthmatics to talk to their physicians about their symptoms and helps to remind physicians to talk to their patients about management techniques.
3. **Through the provision of seasonal reminders, mass media can prove to be an invaluable channel of communication for the government to promote its messages.**
 - a. It serves as an indirect tool for the government to gather constructive feedback from the masses at the same time. E.g. debate over the Integrated Resort in the Straits Times

Negative Impacts

1. **The mass media conveys a wrong message about real beauty to the public.**
 - a. Americans today are exposed to unrealistic portrayals of women everyday through various forms of mass media.
 - b. The media focus causes them to dwell on and judge themselves based on their looks, body types, sexuality and even clothing preferences.
 - c. This Barbie doll image affects a wide age range of women starting as young as nine years old.

- d. They make people focus on their imperfections so as to exploit the potential markets through advertisements.
 - e. Drastic weight control measures are being taken by younger and younger American women, according to the Canadian Fitness and Lifestyle Research Institute.
 - f. Top brands like Calvin Klein, Chanel and Louis Vuitton use exceptionally thin models for ads and airbrush pictures of them to portray what the "ideal" woman should look like.
2. **The media may be manipulated by politicians with their own agenda to hide the truth from the public.**
 - a. The Watergate Scandal: Watergate is a general term for a series of political scandals during the presidency of Richard Nixon that resulted in the indictment of several of Nixon's closest advisors and the ultimate resignation of President Nixon himself on August 9, 1974
3. **The media has created a “celebrity frenzy” culture in the modern society.**
 - a. Celebrities like Britney Spears and David Beckham are arguably receiving too much attention from the media and subsequently the a significant portion of the public.
 - i. Detracts attention from more pressing issues like poverty and world hunger
 - b. Constant exposure to the entertainment industry could change teenagers’ perceptions and values.
 - c. Some celebrities are not really good role models: they are caught in public smoking, or even drug dealing.
 - d. Media may also cause a shift of today’s youths’ focus from the curriculum to the pursuit of popular stars.
4. **The media exposes audience or readers to unhealthy cultures like violence and pornography.**
 - a. Movies like Sin City and Hulk worship the unexpectedly great power man can have.
 - b. Some people even start to think violence is cool and they even imitate the violent actions in reality.
 - c. More and more beating, bullying incidents in high schools are being reported nowadays especially in the US and China.
 - d. The Virginia Institute of Technology Massacre in 2007: not long after the shooter, Seung-Hui Cho’s videos were circulated around news channels, there were others who tried to copy the same thing at other colleges

Evaluation

- Although mass media is important for disseminating health messages and encouraging an adoption of healthful lifestyles, **they currently fall short of their potential**. The realization of this potential in the future depends, in part, **on increasing the media advocacy skills of public health authorities, improving understanding of competing anti-health media messages, and organizing channels for an optimal media mix**.
- **Prolonged exposure to TV or movie violence** may affect the extent to which people think community violence is a problem, though that belief is likely moderated by where they live. However, the **actual determinants of people's impressions of violence are complex**; there are other factors that contribute to violence like family background, education and social status. So consensus in this area is lacking.

Advertisements

- “Many a small thing has been made large by the right kind of advertising” – Mark Twain
 - In 1880: Global advertising expenditure was \$30million
 - In 2000: \$120billion
 - By 2006, by the most conservative of estimates, \$600billion
 - Coca-Cola spent \$234 million in advertising in USA alone
 - Macdonalds spent \$2 billion in advertising

Introduction

1. There is nothing inherently wrong with advertising
 - a. Corporations have the right to publicize their product to the public and the public has the right and desire to know what is out there in the market
 - b. Advertising accounts for 60% of newspaper and magazine production and almost 100% of electronic media production
2. Today’s media is increasingly market-driven
 - a. Advertising is the main income source of a privatized mass media and a significant income source for a publicly funded mass media. Maintaining audience interest is the foundation for their income source
3. Audience themselves have become the product
 - a. The media captures the people’s attention and sells this attention to the firms. Firms use this attention to advertise their products. Thus, contrary to conventional wisdom where advertising is all about the firm trying to sell products to the public, the audience themselves have become a valuable commodity to the advertisers
 - b. E.g. A 30 second advertising slot during Oscar Ceremony costs \$US1million as it promises 60% of American female viewership

Are We Really In Control?

1. **Over-exposure can desensitize us and work messages into our subconscious.**
 - a. Today, almost every physical surface is being exploited as advertising space. More of our private time and space is being invaded by various advertising mediums.
 - i. Even modern athletes are walking billboards and represent various sporting brands and advertisers.
 - ii. Even the surface of the products themselves have become advertising spaces —The omnipresent green mermaid present on Starbucks cups.
 - b. This results in an unconscious influence due to over exposure.
 - i. American children today are so exposed to advertising at such an early age that recognize the McDonalds logo more than the Christian Cross.
 - c. We need to be able to control how much advertising can encroach our private time and space as we should have a choice about what we want to be exposed to.
 - i. In Singapore, all public transport systems are fitted with television sets for advertising purposes. When first launched, many saw it as a nuisance as people could no longer have a pleasant and non-intrusive transport experience without being bombarded with advertisements.
2. **Sophisticated advertising techniques have empowered organizations with increasing powers of suggestion.**
 - a. To lure advertisers and to create a permanent supply of viewers that are receptive to products, it is in the advertisers' interest to promote feelings of inadequacy rather than self-satisfaction.

- i. For example, we are now being told what's the definition of a successful person, what's aesthetically pleasing and what's 'well received'.
 - b. It creates a culture of materialism and consumerism which attunes society to self-consciousness and self-centeredness.
 - i. We have been encouraged to think only about perfecting ourselves and how to buy our way into happiness.
 - c. Advertisements continue to engender stereotypes.
 - i. Slimming centre advertisements targeted at women because that's the 'way to look'
 - ii. A bombardment of perfume advertisements that encourages consumers to purchase things to 'fit in' with the 'successful' or 'beautiful' people in society.
- 3. **Seeing is not believing. Advertisers have a single goal — to make their products appear more desirable.** They may therefore provide misleading or incomplete information to maximize the product's desirability. Common tricks include:
 - a. Clever copywriting, omission or playing down of important information.
 - b. Weasel words technique — use of empty but colorful words like improved, helps, 3D white.
 - c. Digital image manipulation using photo editing software.
 - d. Subtle and suggestive use of sexual imagery — "Sex sells."
 - i. Agent Provocateur lingerie got pop icon Kylie Minogue to ride a mechanical bull wildly and challenge the men in the audience to stand up to prove that they were not turned on.
 - e. Celebrity or 'scientific expert' endorsements to add the illusion of credibility.
 - f. Clever mental associations.
 - i. Linking success and empowerment to owning certain products.
 - ii. Feminist sounding diamond ads or credit card ads aimed at women. "Unlock all the clothes you want in the world" "We are meant to be pampered".
 - iii. Method cigarette maker Virginia Slims famous tagline "You've come a long way baby" links smoking to gender empowerment and equality.
 - iv. Linking love and sensitivity with gifting.
- 4. **Stealth advertising lowers our guard.**
 - a. It's getting increasingly more difficult to keep the attention of the audience so advertisers are coming up with smarter, more interesting and sneaky ways of getting to us.
 - b. Advertorials: Editorials that are actually subtle product advertisements.
 - i. Many newspapers agree to have their editorial content dictated to them by businesses (preferred narrative) in order to get stories that would attract readers.
 - ii. News programs may advertise another program belonging to their parent network and highlight it as a news story.
 - 1. ABC News spent prime new time hyping Pearl Harbor (Touchstone Pictures) because both ABC and Touchstone belong to Disney.
 - c. Advertainmentments: Entertainment that is actually subtle product advertisements.
 - i. TV — In American Idol, the judges are always seen drinking Coca Cola while in between performances, the popular contestants act in skits and push Subway sandwiches. In Survivor, the contestant's rewards for surviving challenges are centre on Chevrolet cars, Outback's dinners et cetera.

- ii. Songs — The Justin Timberlake hit song “I’m Loving It” is also concurrently the theme song for McDonald’s campaign.
- iii. Movies — Some movies can be well-filmed commercials.
 - 1. Runaway Bride secured a deal with FedEx and had Julia Roberts escape at the climax on a FedEx truck. One character even delivers the punchline, “Wherever she’s going, she’ll get there before 1030am”.

5. Advertisements frequently engender unhealthy stereotypes.

- a. Successful individuals are usually depicted as young, beautiful, rich and from the majority races — Chinese in Singapore, Whites in America. Their success is typically linked to a certain type of clothing, car, shoe, watch et cetera — material status symbols. Luxury good ads for condominium and cars in Singapore are marketed with Chinese, Caucasian or Pan-Asian faces — rarely pure Malay or Indian ones.
- b. Such stereotyping on deepens existing prejudices and divisions in society.
 - i. This could lead to increased inequality..
- c. This is because advertisers are only interested in their target audience (demographic group) that is most likely interested in purchasing their goods or services.

6. Advertisements may pass on questionable cultural values.

- a. Narrowing concepts of masculine and feminine beauty. The concept of male and female beauty is oversimplified into anyone who is young, tall, toned and well-groomed donning the latest collections from the runway. Beautiful women are seen as those with above average breast size, long legs, fair complexion and long hair; while handsome men are seen as these who look muscular, athletic, chiseled and tanned. In Asia, increasingly westernized concepts of beauty are being imported into Asian culture — European bone structure, height and build are pushed as ideal. In general, old, disabled, poor or unusual looking people are not considered to be acceptable presentations of beauty.
- b. Materialism and consumerism. The main message that we get in advertisements today is that a happy, satisfactory life can be obtained though the purchase of the ‘right’ clothes, car, club memberships and diet pills. The materialistic focus of advertising has accelerated our rate of consumption. This definition of life is pernicious. Who is to say that happiness cannot be obtained without material ‘success’?
 - i. Consider Bhutan, one of the poorest but happiest places on the planet.
 - ii. Contrast that with Singapore, the wealthiest (1 in 6 people are millionaires) country on Earth but also the unhappiest place on this planet according to a recent poll by Gallup.

7. Advertising uses extremely simple and shallow concepts so that their messages will be understood quickly.

- a. Content is ‘dumbed down’ at times to promote a ‘buying mood’.
 - i. During worldwide debate about the Iraq war, Triumph released an advertising campaign that promoted wearing camouflage bras to stand up for peace.
- b. This is because an article that puts the reader in an analytical frame of mind may reduce conversion rates. This is because rather than adopting irrational tendencies when making the purchase (For example, 51 percent of respondents said that ‘feeling happy’ was a trigger for

unplanned purchases), readers end up rationalizing the purchase. This ends up in a lower conversion volume.

- c. For example, famous photojournalist James Nachtwey complained that advertisers were pressuring publishers not to put his controversial pictures next to their products because it affected the buying mood.

8. The mass media is so dependent on advertising that sometimes they will alter their content to suit the agenda of their advertisers

- a. Certain powerful corporations have shown that they can take extreme measures to punish any media company who portrays their goods, services or image negatively.
 - i. Reebok sued Tristar pictures for \$10 for the scene in Jerry Maguire where Cuba Gooding Jr's character prefers Nike over Reebok.
 - ii. This sense of intimidation and power the corporations have over mass media may lead to media content being dictated, edited or cleared by corporations themselves rather than editors or reporters.
- b. Certain media companies may be inclined to provide publishers positive coverage due to their large ad expenditure.
 - i. Singapore Airport is frequently cited as the best airport in the world by Skytrax, a survey/media company that ranks the world's best airports and airlines. Singapore Airlines also happens to be one of the biggest ad buyers in Skytrax. Coincidence?

Concluding words

- It is very easy to go overboard in one's criticism of advertising.
 - After all, there's quite a bit to criticize — the way it secretly influences and misleads us, the shadow culture it promotes and the way it potentially compromises information and facts.
- The devotion to getting audience attention and securing advertising dollars has damaged the media's ability to educate us and serve to its fullest potential as the 4th pillar of society. That's a fact. But some good is better than no good at all.
 - The pressures of advertising has simplified, personalized and decontextualized information, stressing visualization rather than abstraction, stereotypically rather than human complexity, action rather than rational processing.
 - This has resulted in a dilution of the good the media can bring to society.
- However, we should not argue as if individuals had no choice about how media influences them. Indeed, advertising is a powerful tool in the hands of people with the right cause. We must not forget that advertising has been used intelligently and responsibly before in the promotion of important causes and public service campaigns.
 - Companies have used advertising responsibly.
 - Anita Roddick of the Body Shop has used her advertisements to promote female empowerment and environmental awareness.
 - LUSH cosmetics has constantly denounced the idea of animal cruelty in their advertisements.
 - Dozens of non-profit organizations purchase advertisements to raise human consciousness and awareness about their various causes.

- While it can be said that all organizations are promoting their own vested interests (and to a certain extent their bottomline), if their vested interests align with the good of society, those advertisements can be said to bring a net benefit to society.
- At the end of the day, we must realize that advertising is essentially a necessity in an information society.
 - We still need inform us about the latest goods and services available in the market.
 - Advertising is here to stay. Without advertising, the media will not be able to sustain itself financially. Some good is better than no good at all.
- What we need is stringent guidelines, laws and policies from the government and watchdogs as well as a greater sense of individual media literacy and responsibility.
 - Companies are entities. Entities represent a group of people. People possess the right to freedom of speech and hence companies should too. But if some types of speech are louder than others, is there really equality in discourse?
 - We shouldn't be concerned with advertisements that improve and elevate humanity. We however need to be concerned about companies that are abusing their advertising power.

Censorship

Censorship is the **suppression of speech or deletion of communicative material which may be considered objectionable, harmful or sensitive**. Censorship is the act or practice of removing material from things we encounter every day on the grounds that it is obscene, vulgar, and/or highly objectionable. Whether it is on TV, in music, books, or on the Internet, censorship is an **inescapable part of human society**.

- The control of information and ideas circulated within a society, in the main purpose of altering or suppressing ideas found to be objectionable or offensive
- Ideas have been suppressed under the guise of protecting 3 basic social institutions: the family (morality), the church (religion), and the state (politics)
- Olden days censorship already present
 - Plato of Athens proposed that unorthodox notions about God will be treated as crimes. Censorship back then was a mean of enforcing prevailing thinking during that age.
 - Freedom of speech in ancient Rome was reserved for those in positions of authority. The poets Ovid and Juvenal were banished and authors of the seditious writings were punished severely. The emperor Nero also deported his critics and burnt all their books as a form of censorship (the world's first censor office in 443BC)
 - Shi Huang Ti, first emperor of China in 221BC, burnt books and buried scholars for their critics
- In today's world, societies are now more pluralistic and multicultural, censorship must now balance the competing demands of the societies
- The demands of securing a secular and impartial society mean accepting some degree of censorship in the exchange for the greater good
- While regulating, censorship should not impede creativity and expression in any way, and the population needs to acknowledge their own individual responsibilities through self-censorship in order to strike a balance between tolerance and respect for others

Why practice censorship?

- **For the manipulation of information and public opinion**
 - In 1934, Nazis seized the government of Austria; the first move they made was to occupy a radio station.
 - This symbolized the new importance the control and dissemination of information had in modern political life.
 - Censorship of the News meant that they had been conquered by a successful authoritarian nation.
 - This radio station and other forms of media had been used to quickly and effectively spread Nazi propaganda.
- **State secrets cannot be publicly disseminated**
 - Security concerns and for social stability
- **To block out any form of content that might lead to conflicts**
 - The Government of Singapore argues that censorship of violence and sexual themes is necessary as the Singaporean populace is deeply conservative, and censorship of political, racial and religious content is necessary to avoid upsetting the balance of Singapore's delicate multi-racial society.
 - Commentators such as Alex Au, on the other hand, argue that the true intention is to buttress the continued political dominance of the People's Action Party, and to do so partly by promoting the Government's social engineering efforts.
- **To restrict access to offensive content, especially when one has not reached a mature age**

- Young people may be influenced adversely by the portrayal of violence, porn etc in the media, (portrayed as very prevalent in our society); they may develop the wrong idea that such things are morally acceptable

Censorship in Singapore

- **Media Development Authority of Singapore (MDA)** – regulates Internet, plays, video games
- **Board of Film Censors** – Regulates films in Singapore, puts in place a rating system for movies
- **In Singapore, there is a prohibition of party political films** A film has a political end if it contains material "intended or likely to affect voting in any election or national referendum in Singapore"; "partisan or biased references"; or comments on "any political matter". Offenders can be fined up to \$100,000 or imprisoned for up to two years.

Case Study: The Great Firewall of China

You can find anything you want on China's internet... Well, anything except democracy, Taiwan, human rights, Tibet and hundreds of other subjects including information about opposition political groups, independent movements, the Falun Gong, the Dalai Lama, and the Tiananmen Square incident. Chinese searching the internet for such information are likely to be arrested, tried and imprisoned for up to 10 years on charges of subversion, revealing state secrets or spreading propaganda harmful to the state. They meet a similar fate if they use these terms in something they post on the internet, especially for foreigners to read.

Beijing has the very best help too. Cisco has sold thousands of routers to China to enable the regime to build an online spying system and spot subversive key words in messages. Yahoo's Chinese website warns users that they are not allowed to post content that "divulges state secrets, subverts the government or undermines national unity."

Reporters Without Borders have protested, calling on corporations to adopt and advocate for freedom of information. They have listed dozens of cyber dissidents around the world for their activities online, where at least 4/5 are in China. Looks like the bottomline still matters.

(P.S. Kudos to Google for advocating for Freedom of Information, too bad they aren't operational in China anymore...)

Case Study: Free expression or insensitive and irresponsible provocation?

A Danish newspaper commissioned and printed cartoons portraying the Prophet Muhammad in whatever light cartoonists chose to put him, was defended as a test of whether cartoonists were self-censoring their work, out of fear of violence from Islamic radicals.

In the week after, publications in at least 20 countries followed suit, claiming that the right to freedom of speech overrode any consideration not to cause religious offense.

It's worth noting that this debate between the freedom of speech and religious self-censorship did not occur in a place of political and cultural vacuum. Hostile feelings have always been growing between Denmark's immigrants and an anti-immigrant right-wing Danish People's Party.

Arguments for Censorship

1. **Media freedom is not always matched by responsibility**
 - a. Growing sensationalism and voyeurism in the media due to the vested interests of the media (highly driven by ratings and profits) → thus cannot be trusted to regulate themselves
 - b. Media do not care about what is acceptable or not, but only the hype they create is the most important factor → Increasing excessive and glamorous depictions of sex and violence

- c. E.g: Times and London Evening Standard published a photograph of a woman, Katherine Ward, in the mid-fall to her death from a London hotel window
 - d. E.g: When Al-Qaeda bombed Madrid railway station, horrendous images were recorded by the cameras, and severed limbs and mutated bodies also appeared on the Spanish television
- 2. Protection of public morals**
- a. It is the role of the government to protect morals and removes things that cause harm on others and our rights in the society
 - b. Freedom of speech conflicts with another individual's right to privacy, quality of life, or even life itself, thus censorship is not only justified but a duty of any society to not harm others' rights → the public has the right to be protected from harmful contents
 - c. E.g: Undesirable Publications Act and the Films Act allows government to ban and censor any written, visual, or musical materials it perceives to threaten the stability of the state, promote drug use, or contravene public morals
 - d. E.g: The Federal Communications Commission (FCC) of the United States forbids contents considered to be offensive by contemporary community standards from 6am to 10pm on the broadcast TV and radio. In 2004, it fined media firms nearly \$8M
- 3. Shield teenagers and children from harmful influences**
- a. People are uneasy about many of the media messages that children and teenagers are encountering
 - b. Popular culture glamourize violence, irresponsible sex, junk food, drugs, and alcohol; reinforce about racial, gender, and class stereotypes; and it also prescribes the lifestyles to which one should aspire to have, as well as the products that one must buy to attain such lifestyles
 - c. E.g: By mid-1980s, technology has allowed sexual predators and pedophiles to go online to communicate anonymously and post images, illegal pictures have boomed on the Internet by the 1990s
 - d. E.g: Instructions on how to build bombs placed anonymously by a Finnish fanatic can be used by an 11 year old in Asia
- 4. Protection of national security**
- a. It is absurd to allow real and potential enemies threaten our society by the reckless publication of information that endanger national defense
 - b. The secrecy of defense agencies reflects the perceived the importance of keeping military information a secret, is to prevent the enemy from acquiring military valued information
 - c. E.g: Defence Science Organisation has 4 levels of secret information
- 5. May prevent possible tragedies**
- a. Virginia Tech Massacre Lack of censorship regarding the killer's media pack led to some attempted copycat behaviour.
- 6. Brings about social and political stability**
- a. In relatively unstable countries such as Indonesia and perhaps Taiwan, a complete lack of political censorship allows people to get wind of certain radical measures proposed and this has often resulted in demonstrations, riots, and needless bloodshed.
 - b. **Can be bad; voices of opposition are limited and censored**
 - i. Need a system of checks and balances so that the government, though powerful, remains accountable to the people. However, there may be a lack of mature opposition voices in Singapore who oppose not for the sake of opposing, but for the greater good; allowing them a voice may be counterproductive.

7. **Maintain harmony among people from all walks of life**

- a. Censorship is especially essential where sensitive issues pertaining to race and religion are concerned. As people have varying opinions on the same issue, it is pertinent that an authority runs through into any form of content produced in order to minimize clashes when it has been released.
- b. Certain articles in our local newspaper are held back from publication just because they are deemed to be offensive and derogatory to a certain race, hence pre-empting possible anger from certain communities.
- c. The *Jyllands-Posten* Muhammad cartoons controversy began after twelve editorial cartoons, most of which depicted the Islamic prophet Muhammad, were published in the Danish newspaper *Jyllands-Posten* on 30 September 2005. This caused a huge uproar in the Islamic community.

Arguments against Censorship

1. Endangers the freedom of speech

- a. Freedom of speech is the basis of any democratic civil society → most basic of all rights
- b. Without the rights, children cannot grow into the thoughtful, educated citizens who are essential to a functioning democracy → Basis of democracy: anyone can choose what they wish to see, hear, or discuss
- c. In the absence of the freedom of expression/speech, it is almost impossible to protect other rights
- d. Once the governments are able to draw a cloak of secrecy over their policies and decisions, there will be inadequate accountability to the masses, and it is almost inevitable that further human rights violation will occur
- e. E.g: In repressive African and Middle East countries, newspapers reporting on sex and political scandals are regularly raided by the police with journalists having to face criminal charges and death threats.
- f. E.g: According to the 2014 Press Freedom Index by Reporters Without Borders: China is ranked 175th out of 180, with 30 journalists currently imprisoned
- g. E.g: The Philippines has one of the most journalists killed, with none of suspects in the 61 killings have been convicted since democracy was restored in 1986. The officials and police have shut down radio stations, raided newsrooms, harmed and threatened journalists, and destroyed broadcast and printing facilities

2. Importance of free media in this civil society

- a. The role of a free press in a democracy is to disseminate knowledge, and a democracy cannot flourish without a free flow of facts, ideas, opinions, and beliefs
- b. The free media connects us with various groups in the society, enable us to keep in contact with our politicians about upcoming policies, and keep a role to play in the public opinions → a compromised news media cannot serve its function to enlighten the public

3. Stifles creativity in the expression of the arts and films, hinders its development

- a. Royston Tan, a Singaporean film maker named one of Time Magazine's Top 40 Asian heroes, has made films that try to give a voice to the marginalized in society. However, one such of his diverse films, 15, was heavily censored and featured. In fact, Tan has as a result been "blacklisted" by the authorities, watched closely by the film censors, and shunned by funding agencies in Singapore.'

- b. However, working around censorship requirements may require just as much by way of creativity.

4. Censorship leading to propaganda should not be allowed

- a. Propaganda can serve to rally people behind a cause, but often at the cost of exaggerating, misrepresenting, or even lying about the issues in order to gain support from people
- b. US Senator Hiram Johnson, 1917, "The first casualty when war comes is truth."
- c. Censorship is exploited by governments by pulling patriotism to suppress unwelcome news, with the military manipulating the news on how they are told to the public
- d. Over time, the media covered conflicts degrades in quality, critique, and also its objectiveness
- e. Propaganda is sometimes disguised as patriotism and used as an excuse to control information and having the right to tell you what you can write and cannot write
- f. E.g: Hitler Germany, Soviet Union during Cold War
- g. In Serbia, before the war began in 1992 in former Yugoslavia, words and images of crude nationalism were played, in which this form of extreme nationalism led to the genocide under the name of ethnic cleansing. Journalists who refused to support the government misinformation, distortion, and propaganda, were instantly dismissed, and in some cases killed
- h. Covering the Israel's war in Lebanon in 1982: reporter Robert Fisk said, "Those of us who reported the human suffering caused by Israeli air raids in Beirut were told we were anti-Semitic."

5. It creates a climate of fear and self-censorship

- a. Censorship implies an atmosphere of coercion and a threat of government force, creating an environment where people automatically censor themselves and others → people stop being critical or aware, and they stick to the status quo because it is the safest option → Self-censorship in journalists especially to support the government
- b. E.g: Cable News Network (CNN) instructed reporters to tailor their coverage of the US war against Afghanistan to downplay the death toll and destruction caused by the American bombing for fear such that there will be popular support from the people for the US military effort
- c. Media critics say that Japan reporters have a host of taboo objects, from the imperial family to corruption in the sumo, untouched as part of the news coverage
- d. The Great Firewall of China: Subjects regarding opposition political groups, independence movements, Falun Gong spiritual movement, the Dalai Lama, and the Tiananmen incident were not searchable on the Internet. Reporters Without Borders have protested, calling on corporations to adopt codes upholding the free flow of information

6. Censorship can hurt the credibility of the press and the government

- a. The credibility of the media and free press in a world of censorship has been in greater scrutiny than ever. However, in light of the control the government has over the media these days as well as increasing consumer awareness, it is hard to discern if the media still does tell the truth.
- b. In the recent Iraq War, American military activities in the region were mostly off-limits to journalists. Defense Department censored the war crimes committed by the United States and allied forces were systematically covered up, while the Iraqi forces were demonized. Every mainstream media outlet reported ad nauseam that US "smart bombs" had inflicted devastating damage on Iraqi military targets, yet spared civilian lives. Only later was it revealed that the vast majority of the bombs were unguided missiles and that thousands of innocent Iraqi men, women and children were killed.
- c. The same media organizations reported that 300 premature babies in Kuwait died when Iraqi soldiers removed them from incubators, which were sent to Iraq as loot. These Pentagon-

inspired fabrications were afforded front-page treatment, but the retractions, which came months later, were buried on inside pages.

7. Censorship does not conclusively solve the problems it claims to

- a. It is questionable whether censorship will truly reduce violence or other social ills it claims to → the link between entertainment and behaviours are as complex as the human mind
- b. Forbidden fruit effect: Censorship creates taboos that make the forbidden materials more attractive. Curious young people will defy the bans and make their way to find R-rated movies and pornography websites. By censoring these youth, it is more about sending them a message of social disapproval than actually preventing them from viewing
- c. False impression that the problem has been solved: Censorship does not solve the problems, for instance, despite using parental discretion warnings (PG to R-rated), millions of children still view television unsupervised → Not solved at all despite 'censoring'. These social ills and problems will never be solved and will only get worse because people actually believed that something, censorship in this case, has been done about it already
- d. Censorship can also further, on the contrary, encourage those hateful and extremist views. Extremist people can make use of the repressive regulation as justification and excuse to attract attention, thus find a bigger arena on which to try to publicise their hatred (terrorist groups especially, including Al-Qaeda which want their actions to be seen by the world, thus publicizing them loud and clear to the world)
- e. Censorship seems to solve all issues, but in reality upon closer scrutiny, things are and can get worse than you imagined
- f.

Problems of implementing Censorship

- It is difficult for people to agree on what should be censored
- Differing views on what is inappropriate: hardcore pornography is mostly illegal in Germany but normal in Scandinavia
- Something that is cutting edge and creative to an artist may be thought of as pornography by someone else.
 - E.g: Classic books that were once banned: James Joyce's *Ulysses* in 1933, Allen Ginsberg's *Howl* in 1956, and D. H. Lawrence's *Lady Chatterley's Lover* in 1960
- One group of people can have their own values over the other in a society: When one religion takes precedence over the other, religious censorship turns into prosecution of another
 - E.g: Catholic Church burnt copies of the Martin Luther King's translation of the Bible in 1534
 - E.g: In the 7th Century, as Islam spreads through Egypt, the Christian Copts were coerced into mass conversions that were not at all peaceful
- Difficulties in enforcement of censorship can also arise: Citizens can use websites outside their country and beyond their governmental control, they also can set up VPN sites to log on to illegal websites banned in their country
- Tools of censorship tend to work as blunt instrument
 - Filtering softwares are not selective, e.g: Searching words like "Holocaust" and "hate" will block out most hate sites, but it will also block access to useful and valuable resources such as sites dedicated to anti-racism and the Jewish cultures
- Censorship also takes away the consumers' right to choose
 - The Indonesian government is taking back from the Indonesian Broadcasting Commission the right to award licenses to both radio and television companies, giving itself the power to limit ownership of broadcasters and ban live foreign broadcasts

Importance of Media Literacy → A better alternative to Censorship

- Media education provides young people the tools to respond thoughtfully and critically to media content rather than be mere passive consumers
- Media literacy teaches people to be aware of where information they are receiving is coming from so as to better evaluate those sources themselves
 - E.g: Al Jazeera, the controversial channel funded by the Qatar government, has been banned from numerous Arab countries. Western soldiers were called occupiers and suicide bombers martyrs on this channel
- Media literacy teaches us that media productions are not “windows of reality” whatever their producers might like us to believe
- Media literacy not only teaches students how media messages are made and how they differ from reality, but it also shows them how to analyze these messages, whether they involve commercial advertising, ethnic, and gender stereotypes, violence, sexual decision making, or many other complex issues → people are changed “to be positive contributors to the society, to challenge cynicism and apathy, and to serve as agents of social change”.
- Despite Censorship’s success, it can never accomplish the above. Thus, media literacy is more preferable to censorship, as it enhances rather than curtails young people’s intellectual youth and their development into critically thinking adults

Concluding words on Censorship

- Censoring ugly ideas will not make them go away, it is simply a means of denying our responsibility for dealing with them.
- Umberto Eco, “To be tolerant, one must first set the boundaries of the intolerable.”
- Free speech does not mean accepting all views, it means having all views in the open so that we can challenge the ones that are unconscionable. Free speech does not mean we should be allowed undiluted hate speech to seep into our society, and it does not mean that we can allow interviewees to stir up religious tensions → Free speech does not mean free and easy speech
- Free speech as a price to pay → The continual observance and questioning of our actions
- We should try to enrich individuals with knowledge, culture, and information about their world, and help the audience understand social issues and differences → We should always aim to test rigorously any contributor who expresses contentious views

Case Studies

Media:

- Fervid patriotism has led to a timid reportage of the US government's subsequent actions in the aftermath. Uncritical and polarizing attitudes of media networks were formed after the 9/11 attacks. The networks' desire to support the Bush administration resulted in the abandoning of their duty as monitor and watchdog of policies.
- US film mocking Prophet Mohammad sparked protests in Afghanistan, Pakistan and Indonesia; leading to the death of 4 Americans including the US Ambassador to Libya
- Captains of both the Brazilian and German soccer teams stepped forward to deliver anti-racism messages before the commencement of the world cup semi-finals
- 1994 Rwanda Genocide: failed to make the top of the TV news bulletins even days after the killings started mainly due to difficulty of access into Rwanda but also due to the fact that senior correspondents were busy covering the election of its first black president in South Africa
- Pictures from Rwanda that showed the scale of the slaughter were also never aired as they were deemed too graphic for British viewers
- Talent variety shows such as "American Idol" and "Britain's Got Talent" which invite laypeople to try their hand at becoming music celebrities, have become immensely popular. The products of these tawdry televised competitions are performers of formulaic and unimaginative pop music whose bland celebrity appeal tends to rest on predictable traits such as physical attractiveness and vocal theatrics. Clearly, these programs are not concerned with musical quality, but with manufacturing homogenized celebrity cut-outs who may be relied upon to garner television ratings and subsequent album sales. Once again, artistic integrity has been made subordinate to the lucrateness of popular entertainment — one more demonstration of how the mass media creates mediocrity.

New Media:

- Aided by Twitter and Facebook, youths were the movers and shakers of the Arab Spring. Wael Ghonim, a 30-year-old Google marketing manager, set up a Facebook page in response to the killing of 28-year-old Khaled Said in police custody in Egypt. 'Silent Sands' were organized: political flash mobs that sent a pointed message to those in power, which soon blossomed into the revolutionary protests in Tahrir Square. Updates to the wired world were sent out continuously as bullets fired outside their doors, circumventing the constraints faced by the state controlled media.
- Facts surrounding Bin Laden's demise ricocheted via social networking sites such as Facebook and Twitter. By the time President Obama made his public address, the news had gone viral. In haste to file stories, traditional media not only provided fallacious information about the raid at Bin Laden's hideout, but reiterated that president Obama was deceased as well. News garnered from the social media was more coherent and engaging, suggesting that informal conduits can indeed be reliable sources of information
- Youths Jordan Blackshaw and Perry Sutcliffe-Keenan were jailed four years for each organizing a protest on Facebook, which did not take place in the UK
- There are approximately 2.5 riot related twitter posts
- Extensive use of social media by the young electorate to galvanize political opinions in the 2015 general elections of Singapore
- According to market research firm Firefly Millward Brown, Singaporeans spend an average of 38 minutes per session on Facebook, the longest globally.

- Frontiers of the Internet have been pushed by citizen-journalists so much to circumvent big media's shortcomings
- Social networks services are much better at surviving distributed denial of service (DDoS) attacks used by oppressive regimes against dissident sites
- Social media may be a double edged sword: media savvy terrorists like ISIS have taken to Twitter's hashtag to promote their agendas
- Online social networking creates a network of friendships and a tableau of shared experiences that encompass almost every part of the globe
- Use of new media and the international news cycle highlights issues of prejudice and rally support, as in the case of Saudi Arabia's ban on women driving, US military personnel during the Quran in Afghanistan or the charges brought against John Terry for his alleged racist remark against another soccer player
- Blogs such as The Online Citizen are prepared to challenge the reports of the mainstream media in Singapore and to broach politically sensitive subjects which might now otherwise receive an airing. Media literacy is increasingly being cultivated among media consumers in Singapore. They have become more discerning about news reports and commentaries, scrutinizing aspects of journalism such as the extensiveness coverage, bias and the reliability of sources. New media platforms offering alternative viewpoints on political matters can draw media consumers away from mainstream media channels y interrogating the journalistic integrity of the latter's new reporting and analysis, no longer shying away from subjects, such as the controversy over high ministerial salaries, which challenge the accountability of the incumbent political authority. Evidently, interactions between different mass media channels can serve as a check to journalistic mediocrity and yield improvements in the quality of news reporting and analysis.
- WikiLeaks: Not-for-profit media organization which provides a secure and anonymous channel for sources to leak information to journalists. Julian Assange (Founder): Journalists play a part in shining a light on the secret crimes of the powerful. Wikileaks serves in the capacity of the fourth estate. It provides a countervailing influence to political authority by critiquing political agendas and the integrity and competence of politicians. By exposing the moral failings of governments, ranging from corruption and the misrepresentation of geopolitical events, to rendition and coercive tactics to silence political opponents.
- Julian Assange won the Martha Gellhorn prize for journalism in 2011.
- Wikileaks: Reports witnessed by US military troops working on the ground during the war and occupation in Afghanistan and Iraq. However, complete transparency is not viable for certain enterprises of geopolitical importance, ... security and success of these operations depend significantly on the assurance of confidentiality. By publishing ..., Wikileaks failed to play a protective role, and instead rendered American troops more vulnerable.

Essay Outlines involving Media

Can media be relied to tell the truth?

1. The media is profit oriented, thus it cannot be trusted
 - a. However, precisely because it is profit-oriented, it needs to remain credible to secure its profits
 - b. With modern consumers' wide access to the global media, inaccurate information can be easily exposed
2. The media is plagued with sensationalist lies to secure ratings and sales
 - a. However, few people actually take these sensational news seriously, as they are purely for entertainment or light reading purposes
 - b. Modern consumers possess a high level of media literacy and can distinguish between reliable and non-reliable media sources
 - c. Only the truly myopic individuals living in parochial communities easily take in such information as 'news', and it would be dangerous in the hands of such communities
 - i. For communities that receive a lack of education, with a ruling repressive government
3. The media is a government mouthpiece and cannot be trusted
 - a. The media came under strict control by the governments as they were careful over what the messages were translated to their most valuable resource – the people.
 - b. As the rise of the Al Jazeera and the Watergate scandals have proven, the media is not a government mouthpiece
 - c. Even in the soft authoritarian countries like Singapore, the media is becoming more bold in publishing political criticisms
 - d. Dictatorships do exist today certainly, but they are just the minorities, especially in this globalized and open world in which the media is being the key catalyst of this spread of ideals openly without governmental control
4. News is always subjective and culturally biased
 - a. Information will ALWAYS be BIASED and culturally slanted, it is inevitable because people and news groups view things from their own lenses, as the people behind those news are humans too
 - b. Thus it is pointless for us to discuss whether the news is actually conveying the truth, but meaningful for us to gain the awareness that the clearest picture of any situation can only come after gaining several versions of the truth → and open ourselves to the myriad of perspectives → media literacy to judge ourselves
 - c. The whole spectrum of the Internet content in this globalized world is the testament of this
5. The advertising world truly alters our reality and twists the truth
 - a. This is ALWAYS TRUE as despite our high level of media literacy and our open information high ways, we will still continue to remain duped by the convincing world of advertising
 - b. Our desire for status, wealth, and beauty has left us vulnerable to the consumerist cultures
 - c. Advertising has altered our reality and veered our minds away from the truth → But we still continue to embrace these lies as we love to be deceived into believing that we can be the ones portrayed exactly by the lies we see on advertisements
6. Perhaps it is not whether we can ever trust that the media will convey the truth, but whether we can still trust ourselves to recognize the real truth even if it slaps us in the face.

New media vs. Traditional

Intro:

- The first quarter of 2043 will be when the last newspapers land on front process all over America. This is the prediction the author of 'The Vanishing Newspaper' ...
- Advent of tech has brought a radical change in the media industry
- No longer confined to reading news, watching television
- Click of mouse, people can access instantaneous info and news online
- Proliferation of online blogs and social networking sites such as Twitter threaten to make mainstream media a thing of the past
- But mainstream media adapting to suit the taste of consumers, still integral part of their lives

Mainstream BAD: Comparatively slower in its dissemination of news

- Chicago Tribune, official website chicagotribune.com, posts instant news coverage before newspaper hit the newsstands following morning
- Many different perspectives on important events and issues
- Citizen journalists closer to their subject matter than professional journalists
- Better position to uncover unique on-the-ground perspectives

Mainstream GOOD: Sheer physical authenticity - reliability

- Cost of publishing book acts as a barrier to entry against casual writers
- Hardly any oversight over the quality of material that gets published via new media channels
- Any work, regardless of its value, can easily get broadcasted to a global audience
- Publishers want to ensure that their books sell *quality check*
- Any hack can put up his dribbling on Fictionpress.net
- Any angst-filled teenager can put up his or her macabre, misspelt poetry online.
- Anyone can masquerade a superstition for scientific truth and create a website to scare similarly weak-minded netizens

Mainstream BAD: Profit motive and Government-regulated - reliability

- "Don't let the facts get in the way of a good story" is an instruction often heard in the newsroom
- Concept of media ethics is conceived to be an oxymoron. Sadly, many aspects of the modern media are stripped of almost all ethical concerns. In a reality of competition, ratings and economic considerations, ethics becomes a secondary, sometimes irritating, issue
- E.g. But consider 2003, New York Times writer Jayson Blair caught for plagiarising and falsifying elements of his stories ... clear to public that newspapers are nowhere higher on moral grounds than bloggers
- E.g. Irish undergraduate posted a poetic but phoney quote on Wikipedia hours after Maurice Jarre's death, Wikipedia quickly removed it for the lack attribution but journalists
- E.g. Cover page of economist: President Obama at oil spill (cut a lonely figure: portrays the multitude of problems faced by America and his helplessness in coming up with solutions): Photoshopped
- Inherent bias/political slants
- E.g. Fox news channel headed by Republican supporters often portray Democrats in a negative light. Fox's anchorman compared the logo of the recent nuclear technology forums, approved by President Obama, with the Muslim crescent, accusing Obama of having Muslim inclinations. The logo, in fact, was a representation of the scientific atom and had nothing to do with religion whatsoever.
- Government-regulated
- E.g. With the tight regulations and censorship procedures on media put in place by the Iranian government in the lead-up to the 2009 Presidential elections, any news of a manipulated

election process would unlikely have reached the larger global community. It was only with social networking sites like Twitter that Iranian activists could raise the alert as to possible discrepancies in the re-election of President Ahmadinejad.

- When the media has so many other motives, it can hardly be relied on to provide reliable information. The individual, on the other hand, has less hidden agendas.

Mainstream GOOD: Use professional journalists (compared to citizen journalism) – content quality

- Citizen journalist “on-the ground” reports vs. professional whose sole purpose is to uncover each and every piece of information related to the news article they are writing
- Wider and deeper coverage
- Connections to a wider spectrum of professionals → greater insight into issue at hand
- E.g. 2008 U.S. Presidential Elections (bloggers provide personal opinions about who was likely to win but New York Times invited experts to do a state-by-state analysis presenting results in a full-page spread, culminating in a detailed map showing states Democrats were likely to win)
- Anonymity: given free rein to publish any thought that comes to mind
- E.g. For every worthwhile video present on the site (think Annie Leonard’s “The Story of Stuff”) there are a multitude of videos featuring otherwise inane and banal individuals indulgently banging away at their pianos or doing less-than-funny spoofs of music videos (think the Two Chinese Boys in their dormitory room)
- E.g. Temasek Review: an anti-government news portal
- E.g. Political commentary by a certain Kway Teow Man
- E.g. “Everyone Draw Muhammad Day” Facebook Page. Emphasis need for freedom of speech and expression that is often curtailed in Muslim communities but ended up causing much unhappiness amongst Muslims because the central religious figure in Islam is not supposed to be visually depicted. Easy, convenient, effortlessly reach the global community without any prior checks
- In-depth and broad coverage not found in new media where no profit motive

Mainstream GOOD: larger spectrum of information (range of content)

- Bloggers tend to report more on celebrity gossip and sports (e.g. perezhilton.com focuses on reporting entertainment-based news) (hidden agenda of bloggers too?)
- Mainstream cover wide area of fields
- Citizen Journalism offers us multiple perspectives
- Structure of printed page classifies information for the reader according to subject matter and importance
- Massive amount of (mostly irrelevant) information online, newspaper supply balanced amount of information

Mainstream + New: Take advantage of the Internet AND integration

- E.g. STOMP, newspaper readers invited to post news and pictures that they have uncovered, every week myPaper has a column specifically dedicated to STOMP, in which the column lists the top 10 newsworthy stories posted on the site
- Mainstream media embrace the Internet as an alternative platform to share news reports with their readers
- Respond to growing demand for less lag time in relaying information by setting up websites that complement their publications (constantly updated round the clock)
- Shows on television frequently uploaded onto video-sharing websites such as YouTube and Hulu, showing surging demand for mainstream shows
- Recent nielsen index shows that “American Idol” over 50 million viewers in U.S. alone

- Ryan Seacrest, host of show, frequently urged viewers to log on to fox.americanidol.com, official site of the show, for “never-before-seen exclusive content, including behind-the-scenes coverage of contestants”
- American Idol even has a Twitter and YouTube account, post updates and key performances

Book vs. Internet

Intro:

- Information lives to be transmitted, books served this purpose, archiving, ‘locking down’ and then passing it on
- Preserve and disseminate info, enlighten or educate readers
- Rapid advent of internet has shaken the traditional role of the book
- Ability to transmit regularly updated information at the speed of broadband, giving free access to vast resources, and opening avenues for more people to publish their commentaries or creative writing ... ‘information super-highway’

***Internet more Convenience and Capacity

- For centuries, book was the only tangible repository of knowledge in our world
- Epitome of the writing system, evolved from prehistoric scratches in sand or painting on walls, more advanced than cumbersome clay and stone tablets
- Challenged by Internet on the same two fronts on which it proved its mastery over other forms of recording and disseminating information: capacity and accessibility
- Fabled Library of Alexandria contained hundreds of thousands of books, Internet has billions of websites
- Vast network of information on the Internet readiness and convenience with which this information is accessed is greater than thumbing through a book with the advent of search engines such as Google

***Internet presents more possibilities than the book

- Farthest book goes into another dimension is in the form of a pop-up book
- Internet is multi-media, allows for greater range of expression and gives a voice and virtual page to would-be writers in the world (e.g. weblog, fan-fiction sites, video-sharing sites)
- As a repository of entertainment, at least, the Internet seems to render the book insufficient and in many ways, pathetic

Info not the same

- Internet does not include the entire corpus of the written word
- Books are increasingly finding their way onto the Internet, info digitized (google books)
- Much knowledge residing in books today that have not found their way onto the Internet (exclusive information)
- But... Gutenberg Project transcribes old literary texts from all eras, posting them online for free
- Websites such as Questia and JSTOR store full academic journals, books, newspaper, magazines ... (portable too!)
- Also limits imposed by costs of publication, book cannot contain everything. Editors sometimes forced to truncate minor pieces of information. Internet resources easily trounce their counterparts as cost is low. E.g. Wikipedia or Instructables offer in-depth guides and resources over an incredible range of topic
- Easily edited rather than reprinted (e.g. Wikipedia freely create and edit info): completely dynamic resource, constantly evolving, updating, self-correcting, improving

Not everyone has access to the Internet to begin with

- Computers, mobile devices such as phones can connect to Internet
- Suggest an increasingly wired world
- Restricted to developed countries, and particularly, those in the middle or upper classes
- No access to World Wide Web (irony in the name). While Africans (arguably most underdeveloped continent) have relatively infrequent access to book and illiterate, but written word has greater penetration there than broadband
- Book is the readily available substitute
- Consider “One Laptop per Child” campaign
- Or cannot afford to establish a dial-up or pre-paid connection to the Internet

Utility

- User-friendly with whole range of in-depth technical guides but serve as a distraction, hopping from link to link
- Distractions due to sheer variety of content and multimedia can be both especially tempting and exceptionally deadly
- Clear psychological difference to reading a novel manuscript off a laptop screen and actually cradling the hardcopy edition in one’s hand (simple sentimentalities?)

Narcissism

Intro:

- Gone were the days when the chance of seeing one's name in a printed publication was at the mercies of the publishing house, whose decision on one's manuscript determined whether one would achieve international prominence or be reduced to languishing in nameless obscurity
- The rise of the new media, most notably the Internet, has caused an unprecedented democratization of the publishing process, with almost everyone and anyone being entitled to their bit of domain space and broadband to broadcast their thoughts on the World Wide Web, and consequently to the whole wide world, without being subject to the scrutiny of an intermediary.
- Promote a culture of self-absorption
- Live in a little bubble of their own with inflated feelings of self-worth and a general uncaring attitude
- Afford new avenues of self-expression and actualization
- Transcended temporal and geographical boundaries to bring us in greater contact
- Given us so many new perspective on this world and enable us to take such greater global action

YES: Rise of user-generated content: self-indulgence

YES: Anonymity

- Given free rein to publish any thought, even if insensitive or disparaging towards...
- Empowered to have his views aired without having to consider the potential repercussions and without having to suffer the ensuing backlash from the discord he has sowed
- Identity protected by veil of anonymity
- E.g. "Everyone Draw Muhammad Day"

NO: Brought us beyond our self-absorbed perspectives

- Interconnected
- E.g. Iran elections
- Allowing the circumvention of restrictions placed on traditional media
- Allow a plethora of new and alternative perspectives to come through
- Opening our eyes to the larger world beyond what we experience in our everyday lives
- More attuned to the happenings of our human counterparts

NO: Move beyond ourselves, to take a stance on social issues, enabling us to take up causes far greater than ourselves by galvanizing and gathering the entire global community into taking concrete action

- E.g. Avaaz.org
- Making use of the internet and social media to achieve a staggering number of signatories to protest against the Chinese crackdown on Uyghur minorities in Xinjiang
- Enabled us to actively take part in the quest for change / social consciousness

Conclusion:

- Enabled the flourishing of individual expression, to the extent of narcissism
- New media is but a neutral tool; how we use it will determine...

Private life of public figures

- From Princess Diana to Tiger Woods, the headlines on our dailies have consistently exposed the sordid details of the private lives of public figures
- Such irascible coverage
- Harm public figures / prove to be excessive for even public consumption
- But... upholds the public right to information and potentially promotes better behaviour among public figures

Define:

- Public figure: individual who achieves prominence and often extracts considerable benefit from being in the public spotlight (politicians, actors)
- Private lives, which refer to their affairs and lifestyle choices unrelated to their professional activities
- Subject of immense discussion in publications

Right to privacy of public celebrities is unjustifiably infringed (in principle)

- Every individual deserves a certain amount of dignity
- Actions in public sphere should not be subject to intense criticism based on tastes and preferences of others in society
- Right to privacy does not cease to exist when an individual is plunged into public limelight
- Public life should not become something which can be exploited by media companies to gain profits

Consequences of such coverage often prove to be deleterious (in practice)

- Process of gaining such scoops often involves invading the lives of individuals in their most private moments
- E.g. Memory of paparazzi cameras chasing stars like Audrey Hepburn on their summer vacations ... most iconic illustration
- More insidiously, damage others whom he or she was linked to in private
- E.g. When sexually-revealing photos of Edison Chen and his multiple partners were splashed all over the front pages of Hong Kong newspapers such as Apple Daily ... not only Edison Chen's music career which suffered. Other celebrities, such as Gillian Cheung, who chose to have private trysts with him but did not consent to having their reputations significantly smeared, were unfairly compromised by actions which had nothing whatsoever to do with their professional career
- Psychological stress on public figures when stories of their families and their romantic relationships are thrust into the public eye
- British Tabloid reports on John Terry and the former girlfriend of his former teammate, Wayne Bridge heaped much pressure on the already struggling player and even called into question his ability to continue serving as England captain
- Casts unfair aspersions on their professional careers and produces pernicious outcomes

Since it would be futile to deny the existence of such negative effects ... attempt to debunk the above arguments by presenting a principle that trumps the right to privacy – the right of the public to know the truth

- Isolating the fact that unlike the average Joe, who eschews the media spotlight, individuals become public figures because of the favourable light that the media casts upon them, which allows them to achieve widespread recognition and significant support
- E.g. Without the support of Rupert Murdoch's widely-read dailies like The Sun, Tony Blair would unlikely have won by a thumping majority which catapulted him to the premiership
- Even after individuals become public figures, they rely on the media to connect with and influence the public

- E.g. The success of David Beckham's endorsement of Adidas soccer boots depended heavily on the media reaching out to audiences worldwide
- Thus, public figures benefit from the trust and support that the public places on them
- By implication, their duty to remain accountable to the public is much higher than the average person
- Since the media is the primary means through which the public gets to know these public figures, media coverage on them is justified
- More importantly, since it is important for the public to know whether or not the image that they portray is a façade that hides deceit and socially-unacceptable behaviour, the private lives should remain subject to media scrutiny
- Does not mean that the media can lie about their private lives since the media is still subject to slander and libel suits that celebrities can file if they find the media is spreading mistruths that sully their reputation

Several benefits accrue when these principles are put into practice

- People can check on public figures, make more informed decisions
- E.g. Senator John Edwards, a Democratic Presidential hopeful in 2008 in United States, who fell from grace after Washington Post exposed that he had extra-marital affairs when his wife was undergoing treatment for breast cancer. By exposing the falsity of the squeaky clean image that his campaign team had tried to preserve, ... , the people duly rejected him
- Become better role models

Conclusion:

- Regardless of potential harms incurred because outweighed by ...
- For those who want to be larger than life, they must live up to the expectations

Celebrity as a role model

Intro:

- Mass coverage and the media have infiltrated every last nook and cranny, and children from _____ to _____ know the name Britney Spears, it is hard to question the pervasive presence of the celebrity
- Rise of the paparazzi and the ubiquity of tabloids have made it nearly impossible for anyone with a modicum of, or the remotest claim to fame to do anything that does not end up under public scrutiny and judgement
- Catapulted into the public eye ... bear mantle of the "role model"
- What kind of celebrity statue and what they do with their fame. Parents accountable?

Define "Role Model"

- Depends on one's individual value system: subjective
- Approve strongly of Christina Aguilera's talent, conservative person ... once-tumultuous private life negates extent of natural gifts
- Fundamentally, role model = wish to emulate, personification of one's desired attainment, upright moral standard

Against 1 + Counter: Celebrity image counter-intuitive to role model

- Idea of the celebrity closely integrated with the idea of the entertainment celebrity ... image it conjures is that of a drunk, vacuous and promiscuous person, preoccupied with shallow concerns of appearance and prone to making laughable sartorial gaffes.
- E.g. Going around town without undergarments (Britney and Paris), suffering "wardrobe malfunctions" on national television
- Fall miserably short of the yardsticks of a role model
- Accurate description of many of Tinseltown's most infamous but does not do justice to those who are celebrated for genuine talent, dedication and the like
- Celebrities not found exclusively in Beverly Hills; lend their names and fame to good causes (Angelina Jolie and her work with the UN), diligently working on improving their God-given abilities to even greater heights (Roger Federer), Arnold Schwarzenegger (known for his muscle and starring role in "The Terminator" rode on wave of popularity and fame to political power as governor of California, dedicated to environmental cause, implement policies to reduce emissions and vehicle usage)
- Closer to home: Eunice Olsen, former Miss Singapore Universe: active in community service, advocating various causes eventually becoming Nominated Member of Parliament. Other important causes championed by many celebrities ranging from climate change, gender equality to even speaking good Chinese in Singapore

Against 2:

- Well-known song from Disney smash hit "High School Musical" "I want it all/The fame and the fortune and more"
- Self-made celebrities ... creating notoriety for themselves by any means possible
- E.g. Multitude of socialites featured in MTV's "My Super Sweet Sixteen", who behave horrendously on television for their half-hour of fame on national television, condemning every lavish gift they receive for some minor flaw and generally behaving with a complete lack of gratitude
- E.g. Paris Hilton's infamous "sex tape" scandal entered public consciousness, copycat examples in local context: Tammy Ying sex-tape While originally not intended for public consumption, idea is arguable very exhibitionist – potential of being leaked for nothing is private anymore (reinforced by the Edison Chen scandal nude photos of ex-girlfriends, Madonna having personal contacts made publicly accessible)

For 1:

- Behaviour we often condemn as morally degrading is part of their private lives

- All-invasive nature of reporters and photographers eager for the next big scoop, be it Zhang Ziyi frolicking topless with her Israeli fiancé or Amy Winehouse's latest entrance into rehab, have rendered this demarcation between the public and the private impossible for celebrity
- E.g. Vanessa Anne Hudgens scandal: Declared as befits her image as a wholesome, Disney-endorsed starlet, that she wishes to be a "role model" for girls. Nude photos scandal. Parents whose children are ardent fans of the High School Musical franchise dismayed and condemn her BUT Hardly her intention & human and fallible
- Celebrities, by virtue of the other privileges they enjoy, should bear greater social responsibility as equal exchange
- Media just as culpable (for seeking attention-grabbing story to ensure wider readership) for deliberately sensationalizing these negative behaviours

Parents play a role

- Not to advocate a kind of "Big Brother" mentality
- Immediate influence of the surrounding moral environment probably has the most impact on a child or teen's behaviours
- What are "right" values and how or why they should be espoused

Compare political figures

- Commit illegal acts or influence youths in extreme ideology
- Exceptional qualities of leadership, advocacy or enlightenment on various social issues
- E.g. Mao Zedong stir youths in 1960s Cultural Revolution: lasting damage especially to the cultural and societal fabric of China
- Amount of negative influence politicians could wield is much greater than celebrities as they are the ones ultimately charting the progress of a state
- Stirring fervent youths in the wrong direction, such as acts of terrorism or violence could cause lasting damage to generations of youths and even their societies

Proliferation of celebrity publicity, and therefore the influence they exert, is fuelled by our own inherent impulse to judge – we may in fact relish it when the celebrities do wrong, that we may judge them accordingly; but we must take care not to let impressionable youth, unaware of moral standards, be unduly influenced

Blame media for our problems

Media responsible for problems faced by young people today

- Most convenient scapegoat
- Blamed for anything from underage alcoholism to promiscuous lifestyles among teenagers, or accused of acts ranging from perpetuating the myth of the ideal body to promoting moral perversion
- Some basis of these allegations, naïve to hold media fully responsible

For 1:

- Moral norms are often threatened by salacious television programmes such as the infamous *Desperate Housewives*, or by sensationalist news reports about the sexual exploits of students
- Mislead youths into morally questionable behaviour
- Glamorisation of smoking and alcohol consumption → undesirable influence on impressionable teenagers
- Ad for slimming or proliferation of television programmes in which perfectly-proportioned actors are the protagonists → contribute to teenage insecurity and self-esteem issues (during their formative years)
- Cannot absolve media of all responsibility

Against 1:

- Distinguish between correlation and causality
- Even staunchest advocate of media censorship ...
- Hormones, not television dramas, are responsible for teenage sexual misdemeanours
- Peer Pressure, not *Seventeen*, is directly responsible for creating perception that one must conform

Against 2: Other factors

- Peer pressure, a subtler and more insidious force than media influence
- If one's social circle finds smoking 'uncool', unlikely to take up smoking just because lead singer of famous rock band does so
- Conversely, if one is brought up on a strict diet of only the most wholesome television programming and educational publications, yet associates with peers who consider copious alcohol consumption the ultimate rite of passage ... end up heading down road of teenage alcoholism
- Banning *Cosmopolitan* or *FHM* will not lead to a drastic drop in teenage pregnancies; impressionable girls will not be cured of anorexia just because they are no longer exposed to beauty pageants
- But media does play a role in shaping teenage attitudes and hence contributing to peer pressure

Against 3: Viewer's responsibility

- Giving young people too little credit to suggest that they are the helpless victims of a media onslaught, able only to succumb to media influence without any resistance
- Today's youths do not have to accept the stereotypes reinforced by pop songs or movies; free to challenge the value systems and morally-suspect messages presented to them
- Like all other industries, media industry ruled by forces of supply and demand
- If youths choose to buy magazines that promote materialistic superficiality or decide to watch reality shows that glorify violence ...

Against 4: Generalization

- "The media" encompasses everything from *The Asian Wall Street Journal* to *Teenage Magazine* and includes both documentaries and mindless sitcoms alike

- Only a section of the media responsible
- Also problems other than those commonly cited by critics of the media: academic stress, social politics, a dysfunctional family situation or even financial difficulties
- Hardly blame depraved television programmes
- Range of problems faced by young people is vast and media only implicated in a small portion of those problems

Media's role one of influence rather than causation

Putting aside question of the media's culpability, if we still hold it fully responsible, against all logic, inevitably attempt to tackle problems by merely censoring and diluting the media. Root of problem remains unacknowledged.

The media remains a convenient scapegoat; but to persecute a scapegoat is to remain unaware of the truth

Media ethics

Need for accuracy:

- Joseph Pulitzer "three rules for reporters: accuracy, accuracy and accuracy"
- 'Don't let the facts get in the way of a good story' is an instruction often heard in the newsroom
- Hard to resist executive pressure to push stories further than the facts justify, often by the use of anonymous quotes
- The concept of media ethics is conceived to be an oxymoron. Sadly, many aspects of the modern media are stripped of almost all ethical concerns. In a reality of competition, ratings and economic considerations, ethics becomes a secondary, sometimes irritating issue.

Objective nature of the media:

- News is never a mere recording or reporting of the world out there but a synthetic, value-laden account which carries within it dominant assumptions and ideas of the society within which it is provided
- Government-regulated?
- Profit-driven: modus operandi controlled by firms
- E.g. Investigating reporters discovered that the milk produced by Monsanto in the US could be adulterated with bovine growth hormone. Forced to change the story (83 drafts) because Monsanto threatened that there would be "dire consequences for Fox news if the programme airs in Florida". scared of losing advertising dollars

New Media and democracy

Intro:

- New media arise through technological advancements (e.g. internet) to make our world increasingly globalised and inter-connected
- Democracy whose main ideal is enshrined in our power to vote, requires political leaders to reach out to the masses so that the masses can make informed choices in electing leaders
- Sharing of knowledge and ideas: push towards democratic process

Reach out to one another in a way that is revolutionary and which can never be achieved through door-to-door canvassing of votes and support

- US presidential election, set up political websites
- Monetary funds for political campaigns raised through internet
- Allow citizens to voice their opinions whether in dissent or in support of political candidates
- BUT... British general election (most memorable online moments pale by comparison: first political suicide by Twitter when a Labour candidate posted some crude comments) (moment that changed the campaign was a live televised debate where in a 90-minute contest, the Liberal Democrat leader, Nick Clegg, ended in clear victory and whose support surged by an unprecedented 50 percent afterward: TV invented in 1925) (most memorable incident came when Prime Minister Gordon Brown was campaigning in Rochdale when a widow came over to give the prime minister a piece of her mind. Brown dealt with the encounter well but when he got back into his car, forgot to disconnect the radio and called the woman "bigoted": radio microphone invented in 1949)
- Poll conducted by Opinion Matters: 9% get information from Web sites, 5% from emails sent by politicians, 63% from TV, 47% from newspapers, 27% from radio

Resulted in degradation of political process

- General trend has been in the formation of very cloistered and segregated communities
- E.g. proponents of abortion have their own website and community forum and same can be said for pro-life camp
- E.g. supporters of Obama segregated themselves on the internet from supporters of McCain
- Development of discussions that are one-sided and narrow in focus
- Prevent people from making more informed choices about their political candidates
- Newspaper better medium for exchange and synergy of contrasting ideas and viewpoints as they make objective reports presenting hard and discerning facts to citizens without much bias

Propaganda

- Noam Chomsky "Propaganda is to democracy what the bludgeon is to totalitarianism"
- Spread false information about themselves and their rival political opponents
- E.g. Change their entries on Wikipedia to improve own image
- E.g. Spreading of false claims that Iraq had weapons of mass destruction by the George W. Bush government (YouTube)

Spread of idea of democracy

- Activists set up watchdog groups criticise governments for not being wholly democratic
- Amnesty International scrutinizes countries worldwide to determine whether they are democratic, often posting critiques and evaluations online
- Public scrutiny and criticism often stir leaders towards greater democracy by placing pressure on governments to reform (proliferation of tenets of democracy)
- Also sole medium that has truly allowed freedom of expression (key tenet of democracy) (censorship of viewpoints largely impossible given internet rapidly changing and expanding)
- BUT limited access... E.g. Twitter fueling protests that could bring regime change to Iran (only 1% have Twitter accounts) Censorship (Great China Firewall)

- Closer to home, 3 bloggers detained for inciting social tension through insensitive comments on blogs.

Conclusion: Internet has given spread and actual practice of democracy a much needed boost in recent years but limitations... Just because a tool is new and cool doesn't mean it will have a great impact...

Singapore Media – misconceptions

1. Governmental control in media
 - a. As Singapore continues to brand itself as a global city, it is needed to project our image as a country as one that is open to diversity, change, and progress
 - b. Thus, assuring that citizens live in a democratic and free state allows its people to express opinions and engage in dialogues and debate over issues openly
 - c. It is not in Singapore's interest to clamp down on our media as it will be seen as an authoritarian state which is deemed unfavourable to be similar to other socialist states in the Asian region
 - d. Instead, our government must do the opposite to allow the media adequate space for healthy growth
 - e. Initially, the television network was named "Singapore Broadcasting Corporation", which is changed to "Television Corporation of Singapore" to the now state-divorced "MediaCorp"
 - f. As an industry, the Singapore media is not strong enough as it suffers from the fact that we have a small population which cannot generate sufficient revenue for the industry, and the fact that if our government intervenes, locally produced programmes can be protected from better produced foreign programmes by allocating our local shows at fixed primetime slots to guarantee viewership and revenue
2. Censorship of media
 - a. In its bid to be branded as an open and global city, Singapore is far more open to liberal ideas of homosexuality, deviance, alternate lifestyles, and subcultures compared to more conservative Asian countries
 - b. Censorship is selectively applied to the mass media to curb negative responses from the general public but the recognition that Singapore has many discerning individuals that can take more controversial ideas allows for more liberal openness in medias like books and film festivals
3. State-propaganda in media
 - a. Singapore is highly exposed to global media, have a high media penetration rate, and our population has a high sense of media literacy → the government will not believe that their propaganda will be able to brainwash the citizens, thus it is definitely not a key plan of them to manipulate media to brainwash us
 - b. The ability for the state to reach out to the public through public awareness campaigns and propagandistic methods is increasingly weakened
 - c. At best, propaganda serves as reminders of what we should care about in our country
 - d. One of them main roles of mass media is to encourage solidarity in communities as it possesses the ability to build cultural capital and develop common currencies in people of a state → some sense of propaganda is vital to build our national identity and sense of belonging as a nation together

To what extent has media empowered people?

This generation is one that is so technologically savvy that many have termed the era as the Facebook and twitter generation. Significantly, the media be it new or traditional forms or platforms that disseminate information quickly and efficiently to the majority, are tools of influence that are valued within the society. While on one hand, the media and its influence subconsciously controls and disempowers people, it is indubitable to note that the media is significant as a weapon, or a tool that protects oneself from the ravages of the modern society and one that is used in the pursuit of attaining a better livelihood. This weapon gives people the power, confidence and authority to carve out a life of their own that is free from oppression and the challenges of the modern world. Therefore, it is without a doubt that the media is a weapon that empowers people. However, when the media is controlled or manipulated by the higher authorities such that the majority is being dispelled out from the rights to control their own lives, the media is not a weapon of the masses. In fact, it is used as a weapon against them.

The media has empowered people and has allowed access to information and this information has accorded people with greater control to decide and have an input in their daily lives. In the consumerist world, the media is being used by businesses as a tool to advertise and promote their products so as to attain consumer confidence in their products. The advent of such occurrences among the majority of firms has empowered consumers with information, knowledge and choice such that they are able to decide and weigh between products; they are able to make decisions because they have the knowledge to do so. The media is used as a tool to protect consumers from being cheated by others and in this context, the increase in information no longer makes them gullible to fall into the traps by profit-driven firms. Consumers are now able to make informed choices in deciding over an Apple iPods and creative MP3s. Indeed, the media is a weapon that protects consumers from being preyed upon by businesses and in their venue; people are empowered because they are given the power to decide. This is also evident in the world of politics, where greater information that is available on the internet has empowered people to make informed decisions in electing their leaders. The broadcasting of presidential elections campaigns on television and the use of internet, through weblogs, social networking sites such as Facebook and YouTube by electional candidates, have increased the pool of information that helps the people decide. Malaysiakini.com, a widely accessed political website in Malaysia has empowered the people in gaining the alternative view towards politics. Barack Obama has famously used the internet as a tool to disseminate information and engage the community in efforts to build the nation, while at the same time garnering support in the recent American Presidential Elections. In sum, the media has been empowering the masses with the availability of information, sensibly used as a weapon that protects the majority from being denied the right to make good, informed and rational decisions in life.

In addition, media has empowered the masses as it has granted people with the platform to voice out their thoughts and views. The media has allowed individuals to exercise their rights to freedom of choice. This freedom is being used as a weapon to attack those who undermine the livelihood of the wider community and hence media is used as a tool to protect the masses from the chances of living under oppression. Media platforms are available, especially through the use of new media has allowed the voices and concerns of the majority to come into focus. Activists and non-governmental organizations groups in China have used the internet as a platform to voice out their views against environmental degradation and have even conglomerated like-minded individuals to sign petitions and pressurize the higher authorities to accord improvements in areas that affect the standards of living among the community. In this manner, the media is being used as a weapon of the people to collectively get involved in efforts to improve their lives, and to bring across issues to the government and to the wider community. This effort is an empowerment to the masses: almost all of society's concerns are well advocated for, even in small representative groups. The point is, that media has allowed individuals to get involved and participate in areas that affect their survivability and standards of living. Not only that, the media is being used effectively as a means of communication that empowers the individuals as it allows them the power to attain means that would help them in dire situations. In Philippines, the recent bout of typhoon and floods has forced victims to scale their roofs

or risk drowning in the floods. In such dire circumstances, victims have maximized the use of the internet through their phone and assessed networking sites such as Facebook and Twitter to seek help. This manner of communication has been effective in saving the lives of those in danger and in addition has drawn much international attention towards the plight of those in need. Significantly, the media is a weapon that protects people and accords them with the power to seek a better livelihood.

The advent of the media has empowered the masses as it has provided opportunities for even the laymen to get involved with the world of business and in this sense, individuals are able to attain monetary gains that only augment their standards of living. The media has allowed businesses to flourish. Firms that seek to engage non-price competition through advertising means has garnered substantial profits by encouraging brand loyalty among consumers. Big brands such as Nike and Adidas are highly successful because they engage in advertising to promote their products, even if advertising costs are way beyond their revenue costs. This is so because the profits retained are more rewarding. In addition, the internet has allowed individuals to make transactions online. The adventure of the internet has led to the mushrooming of blog shops or individuals setting up their shops online. Besides a low set-up cost, business transactions through this manner has allowed even amateur entrepreneurs into engaging in the world of business. Monetary gains through the use of media have boosted economic growth and evidently, it is being used as a weapon of the masses in attaining higher and better standards of living.

Despite being a tool of empowerment, the media has flaws that clearly do not empower individuals in any way. The portrayal of negative stereotypes against the weak on television and in magazines has certainly undermined the social standing of these individuals. The media is awash with gender stereotypes that exacerbate gender inequality and the level of discrimination within the society. The portrayal of men as masochists, as well as the increasing portrayal of new-age men, or heterosexual men, apart from the portrayal of female as the damsel in distress and sex symbols are highly prejudiced the society are being fed with influences and standards or 'expectations' by which they ought to behave. This is evidently not empowerment. In fact, the media is not used as a weapon to uphold dignity and social standing, but it oppresses individuals into living their lives bounded by societal stereotypes that only undermine their ability to distinguish themselves from the others. In this respect, media is not a weapon, and does not empower the masses in any way.

In addition, the media has not empowered people when it is under the control of the authorities. The people in power who determine the level of exposure as well as the extent of access to media platforms is clearly an act of oppression. The media in such instances are being used as a tool to disseminate propaganda and by doing so brainwashing individuals to conform to the rules and expectations of the people in power. In this respect, the masses are not able to be expressive and are controlled within ideals that are not empowering them. In such instances, media is being used as a weapon against them. Totalitarian governments such as that of North Korea imposed total control over the media and limit the penetration of media from the outside world within the community. In fact, the media is being used by the government as a tool to control and contain the masses so that they resign towards the ideals and expectations of the government. Clearly, when much control is being placed on the media, the media no longer becomes a tool of empowerment for the masses.

This idea is similarly portrayed in instances where businesses and the advent of popular culture through media that nullifies the masses into adopting consumerism and hedonism as their way of life. Where the media is manipulated to influence people's beliefs and values, too much exposure from the media makes individuals deprived of the ability to make a sensible judgment that is not influenced by what goes on in the media. The portrayal of perfectly gorgeous models and actors on television has redefined the concept of beauty in the modern world. Increasingly, many are willing to go under the knife to emulate such beauties. In addition, the portrayal of stick-thin models has led to the surge in illnesses such as bulimia and anorexia nervosa, especially among youth today. In this respect, media has not empowered individuals far less being a weapon. Instead, it is a tool of confining the masses in conforming to social norms that are in actual fact insidiously pre-planned.

In a nutshell, while the media has its merits where they are efficiently used as tools that empower and protect people from being oppressed under bad living conditions, the advent of the popular culture has subconsciously conditioned us to conform to ideals that suppress our own beliefs and views. In sum, the media is only a weapon and is able to empower people when they are not controlled by any form of governance and are used sensibly by the masses.

To what extent are perceptions manipulated by the media?

The media is a powerful tool that can be used to strongly influence and manipulate people's views of things. With the many weapons in its arsenal, such as the newspaper, television, films and the Internet, the media has the power to influence and change our perceptions of not just things like goods through the form of advertisements, but can even manipulate our perceptions, our views of ourselves and others. It is of course possible to think independently and logically to stay true to ourselves and be able to resist the influence of the media. However, the media can also influence us subtly via subliminal messages that tweak, twitch and tug at our ideology such that our perception has actually changed without knowing it. Our perception and views of others, even ourselves are largely shaped by the media.

The media can and has always been influencing people's perceptions of others. The media, in its various forms through channels like national television, news and to its extremes, propaganda, has been used throughout the course of modern history to greatly alter people's perspective of others and even ourselves. A very good example of this would back in the days of World War II and before, Adolf Hitler gained control of Germany and managed to use the media and turn the country against the Jews. At the same time, he also used propaganda through channels like the national television and began to attempt to create a "super race" of the German race, the "Aryans" where they were led to believe that they were more superior to the other races. Although one may argue that Hitler was able to kill the Jews and attempt to create the Aryans because of the military might he held, we know for a fact that many people, the younger generations especially, had their whole perspective of themselves and others warped and they really believed that they were superior and other races like the Jews were trash.

In today's world, we do not see such extreme examples of the media influencing people, but there are many more happenings going on that we may not usually realise. In every country, the government does have some form of control over the media to varying degrees and they do use it to manipulate our views of others and themselves. Using the more local context of Singapore, most of Singapore's citizens feel that the People's Action Party (PAP) has been doing a very good job governing Singapore. This is largely true, but is it really as good, smooth and efficient as it seems? There is no doubt that the PAP is a good government, the fact that it has remained in power for so long means of the democratic system of voting proves it, but however, it is for sure that various government policies may not go as well as expected, perhaps with a deficit running somewhere, but the government can control the media and cover it up or perhaps, downplay the problem to make it seem more efficient. Conversely, the media can also be used by the government to change people's view towards other groups. In Singapore, we are a multiracial society where everyone regardless race, language or religion. This is definitely in part, brought about by the media. An example of this would be in most local production of films and series, in almost every show, there will be people from different races having really good racial cohesion with each other. This form of subliminal messaging actually influences the locals to be more accepting to others, it encourages us to be more than tolerant and form friendships and bonds with people from other races which is a good thing! We do not usually realise such things but the media does shape our perspective towards ourselves and others greatly.

Of course, now with society being more educated, people do see through these little things in the media and do not resist the influence. Self-proclaimed dissident of Singapore, Gopalan Nair has raised many issues regarding the governing of Singapore which definitely stands against the news and media that are usually proposes. He does raise some valid concerns which make people pause and think logically and intelligently, and come up with their own perceptions of things. Many a time, with

education we do realise that many things in the media are not what they seem. It is impossible to resist the influence that the media has on us and more often than not, we are unaware. In order to get alternative views of, for example, Singapore's governing system, we turn from our newspapers, news television programmes to the Internet, be it Mr Gopalan Nair's site or others. Should we want to voice our perceptions, it would also be through a form of media. We can see that almost all our perceptions of ourselves and the world is shaped by media somehow.

That is all on the level of a society or a country. From the individual level, our perspectives of self and others are also manipulated. If the media like advertisements can sell products and create imaginary differences between others, the media can sell views and perceptions too! People argue that the media cannot change things like our moral values as our internal compass will tell us what is right and wrong. This is not true to a large degree however. An example of this would be the rapidly growing "emo culture" in other countries like America. The media in various places has labelled these people who are just like any other humans many various names and stereotype this group of people. On the side of people in such groups or culture, they will suffer a great blow to their self-esteem and also, parents change the perspectives on this group due to the media and prevent their children for being true to themselves. On the other hand, it changes their perspectives of the people belonging to the emo culture do not deserve to live and even incite people to be violent against those of emo culture.

The manipulation of our perspectives by the media will continue on to shape our views of others and ourselves in many various, different levels. We will only be able to free ourselves from such manipulation only if we come up with our own perspectives of things and have an unbiased point of view. The perceptions of ourselves and others, is and will continue to be manipulated by the media to a large extent and will not be stopped.

Should the mass media always tell the truth?

Theodore Roosevelt once commented on the mass media and journalism specifically – "The power of the journalist is great, but he is neither respected nor admired for it, unless it is used right." The former president of the United States aptly summed up what the mass media should aim to do: to tell the truth and not abuse their power of massive influence. However, the recent spate of terrorist events tailored for the media seems to propose that the media should not always tell the truth, and that there are circumstances that do not require the whole and absolute truth. That, however, does not imply lying, but instead the telling of a partial truth.

The mass media represents the specific body of the media envisioned for a large scale dissemination of information. Therefore, it is understandable that the mass media wields immense powers of influence over society. As it is, we depend on the media for coverage on the events taking place around us and for information on important global events. As Senior Minister Goh Chok Tong of Singapore once commented, the mass media has a "moral and social responsibility", and possesses powers of influence "greater than executives and corporate leaders". Therefore, the mass media has to wield its responsibility and use its position of mass influence wisely – and this suggests a constant, steady, unwavering adherence to the truth. The extent of the mass media's influence means that its every coverage of events would be eagerly lapped up and absorbed by members of the public, and the media has a social responsibility to cover and report events in a truthful, forthcoming light. Society depends on the mass media or factual reporting and unbiased recounts, and the mass media should live up to this dependence and expectation, and be held accountable.

Moreover, it is important for the media to tell the truth, especially when it pertains to a nation's welfare, or is in relation to important political affairs that concern a country's well-being. This function of the media in which it exposes misdeeds and misdemeanour is one that clearly entails a telling of the truth. The media's whistle-blowing and expose on the Watergate scandal for example, shows the need for telling of the truth and journalistic integrity despite possible opposition and backlash. The media is commonly regarded as the fourth estate to judge a government's efficiency, and there is therefore a significant reliance of a nation on the media to check and report factually, the

truth on affairs big and small. Therefore, the media's actions should always be guided by the truth as they have to live up to a societal need for the truth, and non-slanted, unbiased and factual reporting.

Besides its ability to disseminate information on a large scale, the mass media also has the power to shape mindsets, create opinions and mould thought processes. For example, media coverage on the Bill Clinton-Monica Lewinsky extramarital affair created widespread disapproval of the former American president with females worldwide frowning on the adultery of Clinton. The media therefore shaped an opinion on a global scale. Thus, the media should adhere to the truth, as opinions and mindsets are governed and influenced by the media's coverage on events; dishonest or slanted and untruthful reporting would lead to opinions and reactions based on lies. Not only is this socially harmful, it is also unfair to the parties these lies are built upon.

However, there are instances in which the truth will not set one free, and there is a gap between what society needs and what society should get. Senior Minister Goh Chok Tong commented at Today newspaper's anniversary celebration that a media's interest should converge with a nation's goals of order and stability. Therefore, there are several circumstances in which the media, in order to move in tandem with a nation's goals, has to avoid revealing the truth.

An obvious instance is when the phenomenon of terrorism is tailored for the media. Instead of simply bombing an obscure enemy village without injecting widespread fear, terrorists nowadays are known to specially tailor their terrorist actions for media coverage, so as to fulfil the more insidious objective of sparking off panic, pandemonium and distress on a large scale. This can be seen way back during the 1972 Munich Olympics in which Palestinian terrorists massacred Israeli athletes. The Olympic event was specially selected by the terrorists as there would be global coverage, and their acts of brutality and slaughter would be broadcast on an international scale, injecting distress across not only one country – but globally. Other instances include the execution of American Nick Berg and the 1995 Oklahoma City bombings. Terrorists who captured Nick Berg purposefully filmed the gory and grotesque execution process and circulated on the Internet to spark off distress to all who chanced upon the film, using the large scale influential power of the Internet to publicise their terrorist activities. In the Oklahoma City bombings, the bomber Timothy McVeigh picked his bombing destinations as he knew it would be a good spot for maximum coverage. During such deliberate, depraved acts of using the media, and exploiting its influence, the media should not succumb or fall prey to such schemes, and should hide some of the truth of the matter, in order to oppose this manipulation of the media.

Moreover, such terrorist acts purposefully attempt to spark off pandemonium using the mass media, and by reporting the full unadulterated and undiluted truth, the media would be a complicit in these acts of trying to destabilize and threaten the public. Therefore, this is a significant instance in which the complete truth is not expected of the media. In the aforementioned Nick Berg execution, media moguls CNBC, CNN and ABC refused to air the execution videos to avoid causing distress to the public. By not fulfilling the supposed talk of reporting the absolute truth, these media stations saved America from further panic and pandemonium, allowing a quicker recovery from the attacks, and helping to salvage the remnants of American national security. Another good example of how the media should be allowed to not reveal the whole truth is the recent London Tube bombings. Instead of airing unedited and therefore completely truthful footage of the bomb-scene, the news stations decided to air edited still footage, to not further upset the already distressed nation. Therefore, it is pivotal to acknowledge that in such instances, the media should cover up the truth, in a bid to maintain stability and for the welfare of society, and to also prevent itself from getting exploited due to the influence it holds.

At times, to not report the full truth in the interest of national stability is what the media has to do. When Jemaah Islamiyah terrorists were arrested in Singapore, the media had to have the discernment and perspicacity to dilute certain information so as not to ignite racial tensions in Singapore's unique multi-racial social fabric. Therefore, this is another instance in which the absolute truth would not be the necessary truth, in order to protect and maintain a country's welfare.

Therefore, the media should always tell the truth, but at times, it is required of the media to tell half-truths in order to converge with the primary concerns of a country's security and stability. Although backers of complete press freedom and seekers of pure, unadulterated truth like non-governmental organization "Reporters Without Borders" might say that half-truths are equivalent to partial lies, I believe that "partial lies" are at times what is truly required instead. It is far too absolute to say that the mass media should "always" tell the truth, as there are precarious situations in our world that make truth-telling an amorphous affair. Roosevelt's quote on the power of the journalist and it being used right should probably apply to telling "partial lies" for the greater good as well.

To what extent is government control affected by media and technology?

Government control has definitely been profoundly affected by media and technology. Because it aims to manage the people and resources of the country, the government will keenly keep abreast in the developments in media and technology. Otherwise, subversive parties could maximise media and technology instead, leaving the government handicapped in performing its main roles.

The government can use media and technology to control the people directly, especially by means of surveillance.

- Tracking of emails and online or mobile communication video cameras in buildings and public spaces such as train stations
- Busting DBS scammers by tracking their movements, and analysing digital financial transactions of the victims for patterns
- Media and technology have actually aided the government directly because people become more wary of their own actions when they know that 'Big Brother' is watching

The government can use media and technology to control the people by through censorship

- Censorship of other views + carefully constructed propaganda material
- North Korea – censorship in order to preserve a good image of the leaders and country to the common man (even to the point of faking soccer results!)
- By not permitting other views, the government has effectively brainwashed the people

The government can use media and technology to control the people by influencing them, and winning them over.

- In more open more educated societies, where outright bans are no longer desirable, government must persuade
- Use websites to update and present their reasons
- Marriage ads in Singapore by the govt – subtle way of implanting the idea of family and having children
- Admittedly, this is a longer method & govt cannot assume that people are gullible

The government can use media and technology to draw dissenters out and prepare for them better, or co-opt them to improve governance

- Similar to Mao's "Hundred Flowers" campaign, in China in 1957 when he encouraged people to come forward with their productive criticism of the state, the government's readiness to accept differing views about itself and its policy can be seen as a way to prepare to engage dissenters. You cannot fight what you do not know.
- Reach.sg – inclusive of the views of the public.
- BUT: 2011 election results also show that the Sg govt cannot use new media in the same manner as Mao, but genuinely look into the feasibility of some of the suggestions made.

- The government may need to allow freedom of thought, in order to stay on top of things

Media and technology can now be employed to covertly monitor and expose the government

- Wikileaks – publish classified information from whistleblowers & news leaks → can cause embarrassment to state leaders, and tarnish their credibility
- US govt's foreign policy strategy exposed through Wikileaks (get at Iran by gaining Arab support in the Palestinian–Israeli conflict) – this worsens tensions between the US & Israel
- Strong Jewish lobby in the US may pursue fiercer opposition to the Obama administration
- People can lose confidence in their leaders, thus causing the government's control to be undermined

Media and technology can affect government control because it can now be used to commit crime

- Criminals use technology to hack govt systems. Govt can only respond once the crime has taken place
- NASA system hacked into by Romanian hacker in April 2011
- Australian govt computers hacked by Chinese intelligence suspect
- Even if the govt can respond successfully, its vulnerability has already become obvious

Media and technology can affect government control because people have unprecedented opportunities to show dissent on new media platforms

- Twitter, facebook – to unite and, in some cases, mobilise people
- Youtube – to publish acts of police brutality or other form of injustices by the state
- Iranian elections 2009 – govt resorted to shutting down Facebook for a few days, but allowed it under pressure from various quarters including overseas Iranians
- Arab Spring 2011 also facilitated by global new media
- Governments end up resorting to tough or violent measures, which demolishes their good name anyway

Even if there is no dissent, globalised media and technology could mean diluted or divided loyalties

- A people within a country may share interests with other people from other parts of the world and see himself as not just a citizen of a specific state, but as a person whose identity is a composite of identities.
- These identities are strengthened through his exposure to information and communication in cyberspace
- Hypothetical e.g. : An immigrant sees himself connected to his country, to the country of his forefathers, to a religion (if he has any) that has a global following, to other unique causes that also has worldwide supporters
- The state cannot expect or try to enforce undivided loyalty, and must manage this development in order to sustain support

Media and technology can affect government because the government has to think very carefully how it chooses to legislate to control media and technology

- The internet is hard to control: Information can go viral very quickly, but the state may not have the legal authority beyond its borders to stop such circulation. + What content people cannot get from their country, they can get for overseas sources
- The govt must have very strong grounds from disallowing content because people do not take well to any attempt to reduce their freedom of choice
- Weak grounds for banning content. Instead of banning material, a rating system could be better

- Sg : R(A) vs PG or MC16
- Strong grounds for anti-piracy laws to protect intellectual property, encourage a safe environment for creativity to flourish
- What the above means is that in order to sustain control in the internet age, governments will have to learn how to operate in an environment that is freer.

The tussle between private and public sector interests

- The main tools of new media are operated by the private enterprises that created the technologies in the first place – not the government. This means that as private enterprises, they have the prerogative to set standards that will work for them, their customers and shareholders. So they could lock horns with the government.
- Wikileaks continues to be funded, even as governments try to block the site
- Research in Motion, the maker the Blackberry smartphone, has gotten into trouble with governments such as India, Saudi Arabia, Indonesia and the US because it controls its own networks that relays and stores encrypted messages, beyond the reach of government surveillance programmes. RIM has worked with governments to give them assurance that their service does not become a security threat.
- Google posed a challenge to China over censorship – In 2010, Google claimed that human rights activists had their Google accounts hacked by authorities. Google chose to close its China office and relocate to Hong Kong, a move that protected its clients while presenting an affront to government control
- Whether the government has lost control to or gained control from private enterprises depends on how the conflict of interest is resolved

It is unlikely that a government can keep its people ignorant, and so easily subjugated, indefinitely. Even if the people are not empowered with modern technological tools, others around the world will over time come forward, and try to speak up for them. Rather, to conclude, it is more realistic to say that media and technology have indeed provided new challenges to the state, compelling it to change how it operates in some areas, or risk losing power.

Advertising reflects the value of society but does not influence them. What are your views?

- Primary function of advertisements is to market a particular product to a specific audience to generate consumerism
- Advertisements do not present hard facts about the product such as its benefits and durability, but these hard facts are packaged in a manner that is intended to appeal to a particular group of consumers
- Driven by profits, thus logically extended that advertisements seek to create a desire for a product to enhance its marketability and appeal to the audience

Advertising does reflect the values of the society to allow consumers to establish a personal relationship with the ads

- For advertisements to be effective in marketing a product – must be relatable to audience to attract attention
- When ads espouse a value system congruous with consumers → they feel inclined to pay more attention
- They feel that the product is suitable for them, and will be able to help them achieve their perceived ideals
- E.g: Consumers that feel organic food is beneficial, thus attracted towards ads regarding newest organic food stores in town compared to those promoting fast food

Perennial and omnipresent existence of advertisements in today's epoch of technological advancements → the extent of this influence on our values should not be downplayed

- Ads set apart from the banal and insipid methods of advertising of the past and to appeal to the multi-sensory experience of the consumers
- Ads no longer limited to newspapers and magazines: television programmes, Internet, sporting events, YouTube videos, public transport vehicles, etc etc
- Advertisements hold a strong foothold in our lives → very integral → naïve to reject the possibility of these advertisements affecting our subconscious and subliminally influence our mindsets and our espoused values → cannot claim that ads merely reflect societal values, but also have a large extent of influence on them

Even if advertisements do reflect the values of a society so as to endear itself to the consumer market, these values are ultimately crafted by the advertisements we have been exposed to

- To win over the hearts of consumers, products need to be distinct from previous products and shown to perform the same functions better in addition to new functions
- E.g: iPhones, laptops, touchscreen devices

By playing on the innate value systems of a society, advertising companies create products that spuriously illustrate a manifestation of these values

- Beauty and a general quest for the betterment are values upheld in virtually all societies → companies play on these desires for beauty (associated with slim body, sexuality appealing, and physical attractiveness)
- E.g: Perfumes endorsed by celebrities scantily dressed in advertisements → committing a logical fallacy because perfumes are not in fact needed for physical appearances
- Paving the way for more sensory-stimulating advertisements to encroach on the values and judgements of consumers → value of beauty reduced to appreciation of physical appeal → shows how ads contort the value systems of the society
- Ads create an illusion that the product is needed, ads achieve their purpose of creating a deep desire for the product that they may otherwise merely be regarded as a want.

Conclusion

- While it is true that advertisements must first reflect the values of society to ensure that consumers take to the marketed product, it is ultimately foolish to assume that advertisements do not influence societal values at all.
- It is paramount that as discerning consumers, we are not cognisant of the advertisements' primary purpose, which is to market a product in an appealing manner, but also the values that the advertisements try to promote to improve their products' marketability

'A picture is always more powerful than mere words.' What is your view?

In this age of multimedia and high-speed Internet, we are bombarded by images more than ever before. With the advent of the digital camera and even camera phones, anyone can be a shutterbug anywhere, anytime. The buzz on the Internet today is largely over visual excitement such as blogs and Facebook pages bursting with photographs and the video-sharing website Youtube, rather than the brilliance of text. It would appear that the old saying, "A picture paints a thousand words" is more strongly accepted than ever, in the 21st century. However, it is my view that a picture is certainly not always more powerful than words. The power of words remains keenly felt in the world today and is often much more potent than any picture, or even moving pictures such as films, in many cases. Hence a picture is certainly not always more powerful than words.

Even in a world overcrowded by pictures and videos, many of the world's most popular products today remain text-based. Think about best-selling novels like the Harry Potter series, which has sold more than 400 million copies and been translated into 63 languages, or personal improvement books such as Jack Welch's 'Winning', which has sold more than two million copies. One would be hard-pressed to think of any photo compilations that have sold more than a million copies. To be sure, films are very marketable too and attract millions of viewers, but it should be noted that films contain words as well as pictures. Films owe their impact to both; few people today would watch a silent movie.

There is no doubt that many images have captured the imagination of humanity, and have been greatly celebrated throughout the ages. The Mona Lisa, with her subtle smile, is regarded as one of the greatest works of mankind. There have also been photographs that are believed to have changed the course of history because of their tremendous emotional impact. A classic example would be the photograph of a group of American soldiers planting their flag on the Japanese island of Iwo Jima during World War Two. That picture was published in newspapers all over America the following day and gave a war-weary American public renewed belief that the war could be won.

However, pictures are not always more powerful than words. Let us first examine the written word. For more than four centuries, the world has been enthralled by the words of William Shakespeare. In 'As You Like It', he wrote, "All the world's a stage, And all the men and women merely players: They have their exits and their entrances; And one man in his time plays many parts, His acts being seven ages." His captivating metaphor of life as a play, and all human beings as actors, has transcended centuries and ages, and become immortalized in the English language. Shakespeare's words are studied much more around the world today than the works of any painter. His oeuvre has made far more impact and moved more people than that of any painter or photographer.

The power of words also reverberates in many momentous speeches through history. Martin Luther King, Jr's famous "I Have A Dream" speech in 1963 is studied by students even today and long after his untimely demise, the inspiration and majesty of his words still move and uplift people today. "I have a dream," he said, "that one day even the state of Mississippi, a state sweltering with the heat of injustice, sweltering with the heat of oppression, will be transformed into an oasis of freedom and justice.

"I have a dream," he expounded, "that my four little children will one day live in a nation where they will not be judged by the colour of their skin but by the content of their character." His dream came true, and in no small part due to the power of his words. There was no picture that could have resonated in the hearts and minds of Americans and championed the cause of racial equality as resoundingly and powerfully as the words of Dr King.

Words have also launched other great historical events, such as the words of Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels in their 'Communist Manifesto', which inspired millions of workers to rise up against capitalists; the words of Hitler, which engendered such deep hatred in his people as to drive them to genocide; and the words of Mahatma Gandhi, which galvanized and enlightened Indians to seek

change through non-violent means. Few if any pictures have possessed the power to inspire or incite millions of people into action in such momentous ways, to change the course of history. Most people would certainly be able to recall more famous words than famous images.

In conclusion, a picture is certainly not always more powerful than words. It would seem that pictures are in general, overrated, and words, underrated. Perhaps it is because the sense of sight is a more immediate faculty than the mental, emotional and spiritual processes that are triggered by the reception of words. The impatience of the modern age also makes people reluctant to take the greater time that one needs to appreciate a book and much more inclined to seek the instant gratification of a picture. However, a more thorough examination of the issue, as this essay has sought to do, clearly demonstrates that words are in general, actually more influential and powerful than pictures. As a wise person once said, "A careless word may kindle strife, a cruel word may wreck a life, a timely word may lessen stress, a loving word may heal and bless."